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The Gentlemen of the Jungle – Jomo Kenyatta

A Note On The Author :

Jomo Kenyatta (1891-1978), was an African political leader, first president of independent Kenya (1964-78). A Kikuyu, he was one of the earliest and best-known African nationalist leaders. As secretary of his tribal association (1928), he campaigned for land reform and African political rights. Kenyatta included this story in his book 'Facing Mount Kenya' (1938) as an illustration of the relations between the Kikuyu people and Europeans.

The Gentlemen Of The Jungle Summary :

The story 'The Gentlemen of the Jungle' by Jomo Kenyatta is a fable that satirises the colonisation of Africa by the European powers which claim to be reforming the natives, while in reality, they confine them because of their greed for expansion. The story can be described as an allegory because the writer uses animal figures to throw light on similar human situations. The word 'gentlemen' is ironically used to point out that the usurpers are far from being gentlemanly.

The story begins with the selfless act of a man who allows his friend – an elephant – to put his trunk inside his hut when there is heavy rain. But, the elephant, instead of remaining grateful, encroaches upon the hut of the man and throws him out. When the wronged man starts arguing with the elephant, the confusion attracts many animals from the nearby jungle, including The Lion King who is displeased that the peace of his jungle is disturbed by the misunderstanding between the man and the elephant. The elephant, one of the ministers of the king, pacifies the Lion King by assuring him that there is no threat to peace, but that he was having a discussion with his friend. The Lion King pleased that the man is a friend of the animals, assures him that his hut is not lost to him and that he would get it back depending upon the findings of a Commission that would be appointed to look into the matter.

The man, who is initially happy at the fairness of the king, is soon in for a shock as all members on the Commission are animals and there is absolutely no representation from his side. But, his protest is silenced with the explanation that his kind is not educated enough to understand the intricacy of the jungle law. He is also told that these representatives have been specially chosen by God to carry out the work. The man is assured that these members of repute would be impartial in their judgement.

But, as the man had feared, the elephant succeeds at winning the case by deposing before the court the false idea that the man had asked the elephant to protect his hut

from the hurricane at the time of the torrential rain. The elephant boastfully says that since the hurricane had gained access to the hut because of the empty space available, he had occupied the empty space and put it to more economic use. Since the man had to admit that the undeveloped place hadn't been occupied by anyone else before the elephant had occupied it, the elephant's act is considered an act of kindness and the man is ordered to build another hut at another place.

The wronged man has no alternative but to build a new hut because he is afraid that the powerful animals on the Commission would be cruel to him. However, the tale of woe of the man doesn't end with the elephant. The next hut he built is taken by Mr. Rhinoceros, another animal on the Commission, and the same verdict awaits the man. His lot is no better even after that because all the huts he builds are usurped by other members on the Commission: Mr Buffalo, Mr. Leopard and Mr. Hyena.

Finally, the poor man thinks of a plan. He builds a hut which is big enough to accommodate all the animals. As he had expected, all animals, including Mr. Lion, come to the hut and soon there ensues a fight among all. Making use of the opportunity, the man sets his hut on fire and along with the hut, all animals gathered in it are also dead. Thus, the man gets justice by taking law into his own hands.

Although traditionally the act of the man seems to be clever, but immoral, we cannot be harsh upon him in our judgement. He acts as he does simply because he has no other way to get justice.

The Gentlemen of the Jungle Comprehension I :

1.What favour did the elephant ask the man on a rainy day?

OR

What was the request of the elephant to his friend on a rainy day?

OR

What was the elephant's request to the man in 'The Gentlemen of the Jungle'?

Ans: The elephant asked the man if the man would let the elephant put his trunk inside the hut of the man in order to protect the trunk from the torrential rain.

2.According to the man, his hut had room only for him. True /False

Ans: False.

3.How did the elephant sneak into the man's hut?

Ans: After putting the trunk inside the hut, the elephant slowly pushed his head inside and finally threw the man out of the hut, in the rain.

4.According to the elephant, the man can afford to remain in the rain because

(a) the skin of the man is harder than his.

(b) the skin of the elephant is delicate.

(c) the skin of the elephant is harder than that of man.

Ans: (b) It's not 'a' because the elephant doesn't say that the skin of the man is harder than that of any other animal. The elephant only says that the skin of the man is harder than that of the elephant's.

5.How did the lion decide to solve the problem?

OR

What did the king do to resolve the dispute between the man and the elephant?

Ans: The lion decided to appoint an Imperial Commission/Commission of Enquiry for an enquiry to solve the problem of the man.

6.What kind of judgement did the man expect?

Ans: The man thought that his hut would be returned to him and that justice would be done.

7.Why was the man unhappy with the members of the Commission of Enquiry?

Ans: The man was unhappy with the members of the Commission of Enquiry because there was no representation from his side.

8.According to the elephant, the man had invited him into the hut

(a) to save his skin.

(b) to give shelter to his trunk.

(c) to save the hut from the hurricane.

(d) to fill the empty space in the hut.

Ans: (c) to save the hut from the hurricane.

9. In whose favour was the judgement given?

Ans: In favour of the elephant.

10. Why did the man accept the suggestion of building a new hut?

OR

What fear made the man accept the judgement of the Commission?

Ans: The man had no alternative as he was afraid that his refusal to build another hut on another site would expose him to the teeth and claws of members of the Commission.

11. How did the man 'buy' peace finally?

Ans: The man built a hut big enough to accommodate all the animals and when all the animals got inside the hut and started fighting among themselves, he burnt the hut along with all the lords of the jungle.

The Gentlemen of the Jungle Comprehension II :

1. Why was the Commission of Enquiry appointed by the king of the jungle?

OR

Why did the lion command his ministers to appoint a Commission of Enquiry?

Ans: The king of the jungle claimed that he wanted peace and tranquillity in his kingdom. With his sweet words, he convinced the man that justice would be meted out to him through the findings of the Commission. Thus, the Commission of Enquiry was appointed by the king of the jungle under the pretext of doing justice to the man.

2. Why did the animals decide not to have anyone from the man's side on the Commission of Enquiry?

OR

How did the members of the Commission of Enquiry justify their act of not including any man?

Ans: The animals decided not to have anyone from the man's side on the Commission of Enquiry based on the argument that there was no one well-educated from the man's side to know the intricacies of the jungle law. However, the unstated truth is the fact that right from the beginning, the Commission had no intention of doing any justice to the man and hence had representatives only from the elephant's side. Ironically, the elephant himself, against whom the case was registered, constituted the Commission along with the other ministers of the king.

3. How did the elephant justify its act of occupying the hut?

Ans: The elephant had absolutely no qualms while justifying its territorial occupation of the man's hut. It deposed before the Commission that the man had asked the elephant to save his hut from the hurricane and as the hurricane had gained access to the hut owing to the unoccupied space in the hut, the elephant had put the empty, undeveloped space to a more economic use by occupying it.

4. Do you think the verdict of the Commission of Enquiry was on expected lines? Why?

Ans: As expected, the judgement was in favour of the elephant because all the members on the Commission were representatives from the elephant's side. Moreover, none of the jungle representatives cared for justice. They were all selfish and hypocritical people, just as the jungle king lion himself was.

5. What fate awaited the man each time he built a new house?

Ans: Each time the man built a new house, it was forcefully occupied by one or the other animal of the jungle kingdom. The man was thrown out of his own house. The man's state was really pitiable because each time he was promised justice, but each time he was denied justice.

The Gentlemen of the Jungle Comprehension III :

1. Do you agree with the action of the man at the end? Why?

Ans: The man's action can be understood as justified retribution (vengeance, revenge, punishment). We must remember the fact that after having tried repeatedly for justice in a peaceful manner and only after being wronged repeatedly does the man go to the extreme extent of burning down the hut along with all the animals inside. Even here, the truth remains that if the animals hadn't illegally occupied the hut which was not built by them, the tragic fate wouldn't have fallen on them. Thus, in whichever angle we take, the man's action can be understood and justified. We should remember that tolerating crime is as bad as committing it.

2. 'An act of kindness is misunderstood as weakness.' Discuss this with reference to the story.?

Ans: The man's act of kindness of letting the elephant put his trunk inside the hut in order to protect the trunk from the heavy rain is taken undue advantage of by the elephant. The elephant does not have the grace to understand an act of kindness and takes it as a sign of weakness. In its selfishness, it does great injustice to a friend who rises to the occasion in the true spirit of a friend in need. Further, the elephant takes recourse to the argument that other animals in his position would have done the same.

3. 'Peace is costly but it is worth the expense.' What is the ironical significance of this statement?

Ans: The words 'Peace is costly but it is worth the expense' are ironically used because the man had to lose his huts repeatedly before he finally overcame his enemies with a ruse (plot, trick). Ordinarily, we do not talk in terms of money when we talk of peace. But, in the case of the man, peace gets linked to his property. In terms of colonisation too peace gets linked to wealth because the natives are colonised for their wealth by the colonisers. However, the urge for freedom remains alive in the hearts of the colonised and all the sacrifices made will be considered worthy of the effort.

4. Every fable ends with a moral. What 'moral' do you find in this story?

Ans: The moral of this fable lies in the warning given to the powerful animals. It is clearly seen that the meek can overcome the mighty if the meek are pushed against the wall. If the mighty think that they can continue unabated in their wrongdoing, they will be proved wrong by the meek.

5. Do you think the story can be read as a political satire on colonialism?

OR

'The Gentlemen of the Jungle' is a political satire on colonialism. Elucidate.

Ans: It is clear that the story is an allegory with a moral. The world of animals is pitted against the man to suggest that among human beings, some are like animals in their cruelty. It is definitely a political satire which shows the devious (cunning) and selfish ways of the colonisers in their relationship with the natives. The story mocks at the supercilious (arrogant) attitudes of the colonisers who think that it is their duty to reform the backward natives. They justify all their selfish acts by covering up their selfish deeds with the argument that they have been sent by God himself for the good deed. The author uses terms like 'better economic use' to suggest the trade and commerce the colonisers established in the colonised country.

The School Boy – William Blake

A Note On The Poet :

William Blake (1757-1827), poet and painter, was born in Soho, the son of a hosier. He had little formal education but was apprenticed to James Basire, an eminent engraver, and then sent to the Royal Academy. His finest work as an artist is the series, 'Illustrations of the Book of Job'. His collections of poetry include 'Poetical Sketches' (1783), 'Songs of Innocence' (1789), 'Marriage of Heaven and Hell' (1790) and 'Songs of Experience' (1794). 'The School Boy' is a lyric from the 'Songs of Experience'.

The School Boy Summary :

'The School Boy' is a typical example of Blake's 'Songs of Innocence and Songs of Experience' in its theme and imagery. It deals with childhood and the subjugation of its spirit and uses imagery from the natural world. Though it was first published in 1789 as one of the 'Songs of Innocence', Blake moved it to the 'Experience' section of the 1794 edition maybe because the speaker is writing in retrospection about the childhood experiences from the perspective of a child.

In the first stanza of the poem, the poet gives us a pastoral image of the innocence of nature. We see that it is a matter of utmost disappointment for the speaker to attend school on a sweet summer morning when actually he wishes to enjoy the mirth of summer. He is tired and even puzzled under the strict supervision of his teacher. The words 'cruel eye outworn' refers to the authoritarian eyes of the teacher that actually tire the boy. Instead of enjoying the pleasures of summer, the child has to compulsorily attend the school where he spends his day in boredom and dismay.

Naturally, in such a set-up, the child experiences weariness. He sits drooping out in the sea of tediousness. The child resents the assault on him by the oppressive personality of the teacher and the unnecessary words of erudition the teacher gushes out without attempting to understand either the child's intention or his urge for unchecked freedom. The learning's bower refers to a garden where the child can be taught in an interesting way, only if nature accompanies him instead of the school teacher.

A bird which is born cheerful and jovial can never sing sweet songs if caged. Similarly, a child, if restrained under the umbrella of annoying fear, tension and the scepticism of his teacher, can never enjoy the natural instincts of joy and playfulness. A world full of rigid course of discipline will ruthlessly take away the beautiful spring – the childhood days – of a person's life.

Stanzas V and VI are appealed to the alternate authority of the parents to realise the predicament of the child and the dangers in this suppression of natural learning. The boy complains to the highest authority – father and mother – to argue that if misery withers the tender plants, the beautiful buds and the newborn buds, summer can never be joyful. In other words, the speaker shows that a budding child is picked and swept off in the early stage of life in an ocean of sorrow, where there is no one to care for. Its state is compared to damaged nature that can bear no fruit and have no harvest. If care and concern rule over the plants, flowers, birds, such a summer will be dry and will bear no fruit.

The child enquires with his parents as to how they can win back what grief has destroyed. If the plants are withered due to the canker of grief, no fruit will be there in the season of autumn – mellowing years of one's life. This implies that if childhood pleasures and joys are censored and truncated, adult life runs the danger of being utterly dry and unproductive. The old age would be miserable.

All these concerns are expressed through rhetorical questions which have already been answered by the tone of the poem which gives a final note to the reader of the impossible condition of the schoolboy.

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The School Boy Comprehension I :

1. Who, do you think, 'I' refers to in the poem?

Ans: A school-going boy.

2. 'sweet company' refers to

- (a) skylark
- (b) huntsman's horn
- (c) bird's song
- (d) all of the above.

Ans: (d) all of the above.

3. What drives the boy's joy away?

OR

What cannot give delight to the schoolboy?

Ans: The prospect of going to school.

4. How do the little ones spend the day in the school?

Ans: The little ones spend their time in school in a dull manner as they are full of dismay and restlessness.

5. What does 'cage' metaphorically refer to in the poem?

Ans: School is compared to a bird's cage.

6. Pick the phrase from the following which does not refer to formal schooling:

- (a) buds are nipped
- (b) fruits are gathered
- (c) plants are stripped
- (d) blossoms are blown away.

Ans: (b) fruits are gathered.

7. Relate the Seasons mentioned under column A with the stages of life under column B.

A	B
1. Spring	a. youth
2. Summer	b. old age
3. Winter	c. childhood

Ans: 1 – c; 2 – a; 3 – b.

The School Boy Comprehension II :

1.What does the schoolboy love to do on a summer morn? What drives his joy away?

Ans: On a summer morn, the schoolboy would like to rise early when the birds sing, the distant huntsman blows his horn and the skylark sings with him. He considers all these to be the sweet company. But, he is not allowed to do this as he has to go to school and the school drives all joy away.

2.Describe the boy's experience in the school.

Ans: The boy's experience in school is full of fear and discouragement. The authoritarian way of teaching makes the boy sigh in dismay. His boredom and fear are reflected in the drooping manner in which he sits and the restlessness that he exhibits. The books give him no joy and the school makes him feel worn out.

3.According to the poet, how does formal education curb a learner's potential?

OR

Explain the poet's use of natural images to caution the parents about the effects of formal schooling on their child.

Ans: Formal education curbs the potential of the child as it takes away from the child its freedom. The child is like a caged bird in school and just like the wings of the caged bird droop, the spirit of the child sags in school which instils in the child a sense of fear. Children, like plants, need to be nurtured and given care, if they are to ripen successfully and bear fruit later on. If children are not allowed to have a natural childhood, which is spent in playing freely among the natural things (hills, meadows, lambs, birds, etc.), then they will wither before they can blossom into mature adults. Spring stands for new growth and that is why the poet uses the metaphor of the spring to argue that a school does not allow spring to flourish.

The School Boy Comprehension III :

1.Formal schooling not only takes away the joy of childhood but also hinders the child's growth forever. Explain.

OR

Why does Blake reject the conventional educational system?

OR

What are Blake's views on formal education?

Ans: To highlight the point that formal education not only takes away the joy of

childhood but also hinders the child's growth forever, the poet equates the seasons of the year with different stages in life. He points out that what happens in childhood has its impact on adulthood and old age. He questions as to how there can be growth in summer if the buds, blossoms and plants themselves are destroyed in spring. If summer is bereft of fruits, naturally one has no defence against the blasts of winter.

In other words, the poet tells us that a happy childhood makes adulthood and old age pleasurable. But if the childhood itself is devoid of joy, there is nothing to look forward to in adulthood and old age. Thus the poet makes it crystal clear that childhood experiences are very important to lead a happy life and school has a major role to play in determining whether childhood experiences are conducive to growth or not.

2. Do you think the poet is arguing against education? Discuss.

Ans: No, the poet is not against education. He is only against unhealthy practices in education. He makes it clear that education should be offered in a free and healthy atmosphere. Children should not be made to feel like caged birds. They should not feel insecure and restless. They should not find the whole experience of learning to be dreary and dull. There should be enough opportunities to tap their creative potential and turn them into productive human beings.

Around a Medicinal Creeper - K.P. Poornachandra Tejaswi

A Note on the Author :

K.P. Poornachandra Tejaswi (1938 – 2007) is a prominent Kannada writer, novelist, photographer, ornithologist, publisher, painter and environmentalist who made a great impression on the 'Navya' period of Kannada literature and inaugurated the bandaya epoch with his short-story collection 'Abachoorina Post Offisu'.

In the early stages of his writing career, Tejaswi wrote poems but later concentrated on short stories, novels and essays. He has a distinguished style of writing which has heralded a new era in Kannada literature.

Around a Medicinal Creeper Summary :

'Around a Medicinal Creeper' by Poornachandra Tejaswi is about an unusual medicinal creeper about which the writer had heard many stories. Though he knew that not all stories were true, he also knew that not all stories were purely imaginary either. In this piece, he narrates various incidents that led to the discovery of the medicinal properties of the creeper. However, he admits that it took him almost twenty years to learn these facts.

The first incident he narrates revolves around the act of putting up a shade over a coffee seedbed to protect it from the sun. The author tells us that Mara, a servant, was annoyed with Sanna, another servant, for plucking a medicinal creeper. On knowing from Sanna that there were many of these creepers in the forest, the writer along with Mara and Sanna went to the forest out of curiosity. There he saw Mara tying the creeper to a nearby tree referring to it a thief. Mara explained his actions by saying that the creeper was cursed by a sage that it wouldn't be found by people when they needed it and searched for it. The writer counters the story with the explanation that the creeper came up immediately after the rains and died quickly.

Hence, until the next season it was not seen. After offering this explanation, the author laments the fact that even if the creeper has some medicinal property, it would get lost in the tall tales woven around it. The author further points out that this is the fate of the whole system of Indian medicine as people from the medical field are of the opinion that everything about the unique properties of plants and herbs is imaginary.

Elaborating further on why the stories around the creeper seem to be false, the author shares with the readers a few more of Mara's improbable stories. One is about Mara cutting the artery of his hand while cutting bamboo shoots. Mara told the author that he had bandaged the wound after placing some leaf brought by someone and had then gone to a white man at Hulihindalu for treatment. But, when the white man opened the

bandage, there was not even the sign of the wound. The white man, who initially thought that Mara was trying to fool him, was later interested in finding the plant. But, though Mara searched for the plant for an entire day, he could not find the plant. The Englishman who had offered Mara his entire estate in exchange for the identification of the plant was angry with Mara and even threatened to shoot him down. The Englishman thought that Mara was unwilling to show the plant because he was so greedy that the offer of the estate also did not satisfy him.

Mara, who had told the author that every inch of the plant was medicinal, was not sure of what exactly it could cure. The author wondered if Mara hadn't really known the properties or whether he wasn't willing to let out the secret. However, the exaggerated element in his stories was such that no one would believe him even if there was truth in his stories. However, Mara had the knack of coming up with one more story when questioned about the authenticity of the previous one.

He avoids the direct questions of the author about the medicinal creeper by narrating another story of the cowcals – crow pheasants – who chewed the leaves of the medicinal creeper to cure themselves of the snake bite.

Mara's stories were not limited to the miraculous medicinal creeper. The stories had a flip side too. Mara explained the loss of the teeth on one side of his face with another totally cock-and-bull story. He told the author that he had lost his teeth when he had gone hunting rabbits to the forest before daybreak. According to him, when he brushed his teeth with a small stick of a plant, he lost the teeth which had been touched by the stick. The teeth were all from one side because on finding the taste of the plant to be sour, he had thrown the stick away and had gargled his mouth with the water of a nearby stream. When the author asked him to show the plant, Mara argued that it was impossible to find the plant among the thousands of plants.

When the author made fun of him saying if he tried, he might find the plant which would bring back his teeth, Mara counter-argued that in the bargain he might eat something that was not supposed to be eaten and die also. When the author teased him saying that Mara could even find a plant that would bring back his youth, Mara said that he didn't want to become young as he didn't want to get married again.

Even after all the teasing and doubting, Mara continued with his stories, making them more and more unrealistic. The author was speechless when Mara told him that a barking deer which had been killed and divided by him and his friends, transformed into a live deer and ran out of the house when the packet made out of the special leaves was removed. Mara added that his wife, without knowing the value of the leaves, threw them into the fire.

Long after the death of Mara, the author came upon the same creeper again. But, this time it was Appanna who was tying the creeper to a tree and his version of the creeper was different. He said that the juice of the leaves of the creeper could harden milk. Initially, the author thought that the sourness of the leaves might have curdled the milk

instead of thickening it. But, when he tried it out with his friend Chandru-a plant pathologist-he realised that the milk did become hard and rubbery. It was then that the author was convinced that the creeper had some special qualities. However, he still didn't know which diseases it could cure.

The author had another revelation after the lapse of some time when his farmhand Krishna came to him. Krishna, who had earlier been healthy, was pale and breathless. He came to know from Krishna that he was passing blood with stool and he suspected it to be piles. When Krishna went to the hospital, the doctors advised him surgery. Krishna was scared of surgery. Moreover, earlier Krishna had been cured of rashes by a Malayali sadhu who had asked Krishna to mix the crushed bark of a tree with duck's eggs and eat. But, this time the sadhu who had grown old described the plant to Krishna as he had no strength to search for the plant.

Since the description matched the features of the miracle creeper, the author took him to the creeper which Appanna had tied to a tree and Krishna drank the ground tuber of the creeper with milk. He was completely cured in five days. Moreover, the author who had eaten a small piece of the root to see how it tasted, got cured of the pain in his heel. The swelling that had developed next to the bone of the heel for which the surgeon had recommended surgery, also disappeared.

The author, even after the cure, has a few doubts. He wonders whether the cure is coincidental or the effect of the medicinal quality of the plant. Even if it were to be the effect of medicine, he knows that he cannot be sure of which type of swelling would be cured by the creeper. With these questions in mind, the author concedes that Indian medicine, even if effective, suffers from the problem of the native doctors not sharing their knowledge with others because of their fear that if spoken about, the plant would lose its medicinal quality. He avers that this situation has brought India's native medicinal systems to the verge of extinction.

Around a Medicinal Creeper Comprehension I :

1.What did Mara do when he found the creeper?

OR

Where did Mara tie the creeper?

Ans: Mara caught hold of one of the tendrils of the creeper and tied it to a nearby tree.

2.Mention the curse about the medicinal plant.

OR

What was the curse of the sage on the medicinal creeper as narrated by Mara?

Ans: The curse on the plant by a sage is that when someone needs the plant, he will not find it. It was this curse which led to the practice of tying the creeper to a nearby tree so that people would find it when they needed it.

3.What surprised the white man?

OR

What surprised the white man when he removed the bandage on Mara's hand?

Ans: The white man was surprised that Mara's wounded hand had got cured within a couple of hours of getting cut, just by placing the leaf of a medicinal plant on the wound and bandaging it.

4.How did the mongoose and the cowcal cure themselves of a snake bite?

OR

Why do the mongoose and the cowcal chew the medicinal creeper?

Ans: They chewed the leaf of the medicinal plant if they were bitten by a snake.

5.Why had Mara lost his teeth on the right side?

Ans: Mara had brushed the right side of his mouth with a small stick broken from a nearby plant and when he gargled and spat the water out, the teeth which had been touched by the stick tumbled out of his mouth.

6.What did Mara's wife find on opening the packet of meat?

Ans: Mara's wife found a live wild buck instead of the meat of the barking deer on opening the packet.

7.What happened when milk was mixed with the juice of the creeper's leaves?

OR

What was the effect of the juice of the medicinal creeper on milk?

Ans: The milk became thick.

8.When would the medicines lose their potency, according to the belief of native doctors?

Ans: The native doctors believed that if they told others about their medicines, the medicines would lose their potency.

Around a Medicinal Creeper Comprehension II :

1.How long did it take the narrator to learn the facts about the medicinal creeper? What does it signify?

Ans: It took almost twenty years for the narrator to learn the facts about the medicinal creeper. First of all, it shows that not enough research work has gone into the field of herbal medicine. The illiterate natives know that some plants are medicinal, but they don't know the exact benefits that can be reaped from these plants. Moreover, even the ones who know the value of the plants don't let out the secret because of the belief that if spoken about, the plant might lose its potency. There is also the question of exaggeration.

People like Mara knowingly or unknowingly add a few juicy bits to their experiences and hence, for a third person, it's difficult to differentiate between fact and fiction. As a result, even a fact is confused about fiction. Lastly, even people like the narrator, who have an interest in the medicinal plants and conclusive proof of its benefits fail to pursue the matter in a consistent manner with concerted efforts.

2.What does the incident of Mara's wife throwing the leaves into fire tell us about Indians in general?

OR

The incident of Mara's wife throwing the leaves into the fire reflects the ignorance of India's native medicinal systems. Discuss.

Ans: When a live wild buck appeared in the place of the meat of the barking deer and ran away, Mara ran after it. Mara's wife, without knowing anything about the background of the episode, picked up the leaves and threw them into the fire. It shows that even after such an unusual incident of the dead meat turning into a live animal, the woman was not interested in finding out what could have led to the miracle. It shows the casual attitude Indians have towards the medicinal plants.

3.How was Krishna cured of his illness?

OR

How was Krishna cured of piles?

Ans: Krishna had piles problem and the only cure for it in allopathy was surgery. Krishna, an illiterate, was terrified of surgery and hence he went to the village godman for treatment. The godman, being old, could only give the description of the plant which could be used for his cure.

Since the description matched the features of the miracle creeper, the author took him to the creeper which Appanna had tied to a tree and Krishna drank the ground tuber of the creeper with milk. He was cured completely in five days.

Around a Medicinal Creeper Comprehension III :

1. Do you think the author is suggesting that Indian herbal medicine is better/safer than allopathic medicine? Discuss.

Ans: Yes, he does. Although he expresses doubt over the incredible stories of Mara about the efficacy of certain herbs and plants, he shows very clearly that Indian herbal medicine can work wonders with illnesses which in allopathic medicine have either no cure or cure only through surgery with all its associated problems.

Right at the beginning of the piece, he avers that out of the many stories about an unusual medicinal creeper, though some are imaginary and some false, some are true also. He also states that it took him twenty years to arrive at the facts with regard to this creeper. Though he keeps referring to Mara's stories as improbable, he concedes that not all of them can be dismissed as bunkum. Even after Mara's death, the author is troubled by what Mara had to say about many a plant in the forest. His speculations get a fillip when milk gets curdled and becomes rubbery after squeezing the juice of the medicinal creeper he had seen Mara and Appanna tying to a tree into the milk.

Although he is still not sure of what medicinal quality the creeper might have had, he is certain that the creeper has certain unusual qualities. The incident with Krishna, his former farmhand, further confirms his notion. First of all, the writer tells us that Krishna was cured of his rashes by the medicine given by a Malayali Sadhu, concocted out of the bark of some tree crushed and mixed with duck's eggs and eaten. Secondly, the writer cites the incident of Krishna getting cured of his piles by drinking the ground root of a creeper, mixed with milk. Further, the author points out that just by eating a small piece of the tuber to see how it tasted, he seemed to have helped his heel which had been paining for quite some time.

The swelling that had appeared next to the bone of the heel also disappeared. Though the writer is not very sure whether the healing is the result of the medicinal properties of the creeper or not, he is of the opinion that the possibility is worth exploring. That is why he laments that India's native medicinal systems are on the verge of extinction.

2. What has made the modern man lose the knowledge of traditional medicine?

Ans: As the author himself points out, the belief of the native doctors that if they told others about their medicines, the medicines would lose their potency has resulted in the loss of knowledge of traditional medicine. Secondly, since the sadhus and godmen have more or less been illiterate, the knowledge has not been carried forth in the written format. Thirdly, those like Mara who have benefited from such medicines, exaggerate the facts and hence the facts are mistaken for fiction. Fourthly, even the educated lot, like the author himself, take a long time even to pursue the matter and see if there is truth in the claims made by people such as Mara. In addition to all this, Ayurveda is dismissed by allopathic practitioners as bunkum.

So, Ayurveda has to fight the ignorance of the illiterate and the arrogance of the literate. Moreover, it has to combat the indifference of the government which has not really tried in a significant way to explore the possibilities of ayurvedic cure.

3. 'Our natural resources are our vital resources'. Explain the statement in light of several 'developmental' projects that are being promoted today.

Ans: India is a peninsula covered by water on three sides and protected by the Himalayas on the other. The land has many mountains and rivers and three-fourth of our land is agricultural. In addition, our human resource, which is also a natural resource, is strong. Thus, the topography and eugenics of India make it very clear that our natural resources are our vital resources. Hence, we should try to improve our economy in the area of natural resources instead of technology and industry.

When we do this we will tap the potential of our human resource. But, the sorry state of affairs is that we are promoting projects which harm natural resources as they involve machines instead of people. It is farcical that we consider them 'developmental'. They are far from being developmental and they have brought the nation and the people of the nation to the brink of disaster. We should have projects which would tap solar energy, harvest rainwater, and recycle natural resources.

Oru Manushyan - Vaikom Muhammad Basheer

A Note On The Author :

Vaikom Muhammad Basheer (1908-1994) is a well-known Malayalam short story writer and novelist. He is known for his sympathetic portrayal of the joys and sorrows of ordinary life. His stories have been translated into English and various Indian languages. He was an honorary fellow of the Sahitya Akademi in 1970. He was the recipient of the Central Sahitya Akademi Award and Padmashri in 1982.

Oru Manushyan Summary :

'Oru Manushyan' when translated to English means 'A Man' and the title refers to a man who comes to the rescue of the speaker, who is in a land which is one thousand five hundred miles away from his home. The speaker knows no one there; neither does he know the local language. He knows English and Hindustani, but not many inhabitants of the land understand English or Hindustani. The place is quite a big city in the valley of a mountain. The crime rate is high as the people are merciless and are prepared to do anything for money. They work as soldiers, money lenders and watchmen in banks/mills/commercial establishments.

The speaker, who stays in a small room, teaches English to migrant labourers from nine-thirty till eleven in the night as people want to learn English to write addresses in English at the post office. If they have to get it done by others, they have to pay anything between one anna and four annas. The speaker, who earns very little, sleeps all day and wakes up at four in the evening so as to avoid the expenses of morning tea and noon lunch.

One evening he goes to a crowded restaurant to have his food and when he has to pay the bill of eleven annas, he realises that his purse with his life's savings of fourteen rupees is missing. But, the owner of the restaurant thinks that the speaker is trying to cheat him, and threatens to gouge his eyes out. None of the others at the restaurant seem to have any kindness either. The speaker pleads with the owner to keep his coat as surety. But, the owner guffaws and makes the speaker remove his coat, shirt, and shoes. When he wants the speaker to remove even the trousers, the speaker pleads with him for mercy saying he has nothing inside. This only invokes more laughter and the restaurant owner, along with fifty other people gathered there, forces the speaker to strip further, and says mockingly, "There must be something inside."

The speaker, now resigned to his fate, starts unbuttoning his trousers, all the time imagining himself standing naked in front of others, with his eyes gouged out. It is at this

point that a blue-eyed, fair-complexioned, a six-footer with a red turban and white trousers intervenes and offers to pay the amount due, to the owner. He asks the speaker to go with him and when the grateful speaker asks for his name, he says he has no name. When the speaker says 'Mercy' must be his name, he does not react and walks on until they reach a deserted bridge. There, after making sure that no one is around, the stranger takes out five wallets and asks the speaker which of these is his. He warns the speaker to go away without turning around and adds that the speaker should not admit to anyone that he has seen the man. He gives the wallet, which has been identified by the speaker as his own, with the money intact, and leaves the place wishing the speaker that he be helped by God. The speaker, on his part, hopes that God would help the stranger.

It is clear that the man, who helps the speaker, in reality, is the pick-pocket who has stolen the purse of the speaker, in addition to four other wallets. Though the speaker is more than grateful to the man, the situation raises many ethical questions. Do we take the pick-pocket as a man with a kind heart? Following one line of argument, we can say that he definitely is. Otherwise, he wouldn't have helped the speaker. Had he been totally hard-hearted, he would have probably had a lot of fun, watching the humiliation of the speaker, knowing full well that the speaker is telling the truth. One more point that goes in his favour is the truth that the money he pays at the restaurant is not from the fourteen rupees of the speaker. In fact, he asks the speaker to count his money and make sure that the amount is not touched.

But, this doesn't absolve him of wrongdoing. What would have happened to the speaker if the man who had picked his pocket wasn't around? What about the plight of the other four people who have lost their wallets? Isn't there the possibility that they too would probably be in similar or even worse situations? There is also the question of the background of the thief. Has he indulged in the crime because of some unavoidable circumstances or is it that he is a man who wants to earn some quick money? The various ethical questions point in one direction – we cannot sit in judgment of the actions of others. No case can be judged from a single point of view. There are multiple possibilities. However, it is evident that, though a criminal, the man – 'Oru Manushyan' – is certainly a person with some goodness in his heart and the speaker would always remember him as his kind saviour.

Oru Manushyan Comprehension I :

1.How far was the big city from the narrator's home-town?

Ans: Around a thousand five hundred miles.

2.Where did the narrator stay in the big city?

Ans: In a very small, dingy room.

3.For the money, people would do anything, even _____ (Fill in the blank)

Ans: commit murder.

4.What was the narrator doing to earn a living?

OR

How did the narrator earn his living in 'Oru Manushyan'?

OR

What did the narrator teach the migrant labourers in 'Oru Manushyan'?

Ans: He taught English to some migrant labourers.

5. _____ was considered a great education there.

(a) Learning English

(b) Learning to write an address in English

(c) Writing addresses at the post-office.

Ans: (b) Learning to write an address in English.

6.What reason did the narrator give for sleeping all day and having food in the evening?

OR

Why did the narrator have food only in the evening?

Ans: So that he could save the expense of drinking his morning tea and eating the noon meal.

7.How much money did the narrator have in his pocket as his life's savings?

OR

What was the narrator's life's savings?

Ans: Fourteen Rupees.

8.The man who came forward to pay the narrator's bill was

(a) a man with a red turban.

(b) a person dressed in a suit.

(c) a money lender.

Ans: (a) A man with a red turban.

Oru Manushyan Comprehension II :

1. Describe the people and the place where the incident took place.

OR

What does the narrator say about the people of the city where he lived?

OR

Describe the people and the place where the narrator stayed.

Ans: The place was quite a big city in the valley of a mountain. The inhabitants did not have the virtue of mercy in their heart and were a cruel lot. They were ready to do anything for money. Shocking incidents like murder, robbery, pickpocketing were the order of the day. The inhabitants worked as soldiers, money lenders and watchmen in banks/mills/commercial establishments. They had no knowledge of English and it was as though they were content in their own small world of malice and meanness.

2. What was the routine of the narrator in the city?

Ans: There was nothing exciting about the routine of the narrator in the city. He taught the migrant labourers English as they wanted to write addresses in English at the post office. As they were working people, he could teach them only in the evening. Usually, his teaching went on from nine-thirty till eleven in the night. Since he earned very little, he slept the whole day and woke up at four in the evening so as to avoid the expenses of morning tea and noon lunch.

3. Give an account of the embarrassing experience of the narrator at the restaurant?

Ans: One evening the narrator goes to a crowded restaurant to have his food and when he has to pay the bill of eleven annas, he realises that his purse with his life's savings of fourteen rupees is missing. But, the owner of the restaurant thinks that the speaker is trying to cheat him, and threatens to gouge his eyes out. None of the others at the restaurant seem to have any kindness either. The speaker pleads with the owner to keep his coat as surety. But, the owner guffaws and makes the speaker remove his coat, shirt, and shoes.

When he wants the speaker to remove even the trousers, the speaker pleads with him for mercy saying he has nothing inside. This only invokes more laughter and the restaurant owner, along with fifty other people gathered there, forces the speaker to strip further saying mockingly, "There must be something inside." The speaker, now resigned to his fate, starts unbuttoning his trousers, all the time imagining himself standing naked in front of others, with his eyes gouged out.

We see that the narrator is not only embarrassed but also humiliated. Since he is not a cheat, it must have been terribly embarrassing for him to have realised that he had eaten his food at the restaurant, but had no money to pay for the food. His embarrassment would have increased when the owner of the restaurant treated him as

a cheat. But, to top it all, the cruel way in which not only the owner but also the people gathered there treated him would have been humiliating for the narrator.

4.A stranger saved the day for the narrator. How?

OR

How did the stranger come to the help of the narrator?

OR

How does the stranger rescue the narrator in 'Oru Manushyan'?

Ans: When the narrator is at the point of removing his trousers though he has nothing inside, a blue-eyed, fair-complexioned six-footer, with a red turban and white trousers, intervenes and offers to pay the amount due from the narrator to the restaurant owner. He asks the speaker to go with him and when the grateful speaker asks for his name, he says he has no name. When the speaker says 'Mercy' must be his name, he does not react and walks on until they reach a deserted bridge.

There, after making sure that no one is around, the stranger takes out five wallets and asks the speaker which of these is his. He warns the speaker to go away without turning around and adds that the speaker should not admit to anyone that he has seen the man. He gives the wallet, which has been identified by the speaker, with the money intact and leaves the place wishing the speaker that he be helped by God. The speaker, on his part, hopes that God would help the stranger.

Thus we see that the pickpocket helps the narrator not only at the restaurant but also outside by returning the purse. This is how the act of kindness gains insignificance. First of all the pickpocket is good enough to help the man who faces humiliation as he has lost his purse; secondly, he is kind enough to return the purse; thirdly, the eleven annas that he pays is not the narrator's money, but his own.

Oru Manushyan Comprehension III :

1.Does the story 'Oru Manushyan' talk about transformation in a person/man? Discuss.

OR

'Oru Manushyan' exemplifies the transformation of a human being. Substantiate.

Ans: Yes, indeed. The transformation is seen in the pick-pocket. The pickpocket not only helps the narrator at the restaurant but also helps him further by returning the purse. This is how the act of kindness gains in significance. First of all the pickpocket is good enough to help the man who faces humiliation as he has lost his purse; secondly, he is kind enough to return the purse; thirdly, the twelve annas that he pays is not the narrator's money, but his own. Perhaps the pickpocket, until then, was not a witness to the problems created for people from whom he had stolen their purse. Maybe the

narrator's plight reveals to him for the first time glimpses of the problems faced by people when they lose their purse, with their hard-earned money in it. That is why, despite the fact that people at that place were usually merciless, we see a transformation taking place in the heart of the pick-pocket.

2. Do you think the restaurant keeper was over-reacting when the narrator could not pay the bill? If so, what accounts for his behaviour?

Ans: Yes, he was. He gives the narrator no chance at all. It is as if all those who claimed to have lost their purse were liars. Even when the narrator asks him to keep his coat, he shows no leniency. He has a lot of sadistic pleasure at the cost of the narrator while forcing him to strip. He comes out as a cruel man who has no pity at all for people with problems.

However, there is the possibility that he has turned out to be so cruel after bitter experiences. If we consider the fact that the people of that place were ready to do anything for money, we should understand that the restaurant owner might have had people duping him with a cock-and-bull story of losing the purse. Maybe over the years, he has lost his gentleness and hence goes to the extreme extent of ill-treating such people so that others wouldn't dare come up with lies.

All said and done, the final word on the restaurant owner is that he comes out as merciless. He could have made the narrator do some work in his restaurant to make up for the eleven annas. But, he gives absolutely no chance to the narrator and humiliates him cruelly.

Money Madness - D.H. Lawrence

A Note On The Poet :

D.H. Lawrence [1885-1930] was a prominent twentieth-century English writer. He has to his credit several novels, short stories, poems, plays, essays, travel books and translations. He is noted for his novels, especially 'Sons and Lovers', 'The Rainbow' and 'Women in Love.' In the poem 'Money Madness,' the poet perceives the materialistic perspective of his fellow human beings. The poet goes on to project a future which ushers in a moneyless society.

Money Madness Summary :

'Money Madness' by D.H. Lawrence is a powerful argument against the weakness of money. Lawrence begins by saying that madness for money is collective. With this, he establishes the fact that the madness for money is widespread and is rampant. But Lawrence is quick to add that an individual is not absolved of guilt just because this madness is all-pervasive. He has to admit to his own share of insanity because collective madness is possible only after individual madness comes into existence. Thus the poet points out that money is a madness shared by everyone in the world. If the whole world is mad, then every single person carries the madness around him.

The poet is afraid of society. If a man becomes so consumed by money, he forgets what else is important in the world. Financial issues are stressful. Often, society judges a man by his riches. If he is poor, then society expects him to eat dirt or beg for bread. Lawrence emphasizes that the world has become preoccupied with money and the ways in which one can possess wealth. It is madness to place such importance on money which can be lost in the blink of an eye. People do not like to share their money. The larger the amount, the more painful it becomes to give it away. Man cowers before the god of wealth – Money can stress a person. The consumption of riches has power over man. It is the collective or shared wealth that is most frightening. The narrator hopes that if he has no money, mankind will give him bread so that he might live. But he also knows that along with bread, people will make him eat dirt.

This fear of the 'money-hungry fellow man' can confuse a person. To summarize his point, Lawrence avows that people should not have to beg for food to eat. Food, shelter, and fire should be free for everyone. Mankind must regain its composure concerning the financial aspect of life before we start killing one another over it.

Money Madness Comprehension I :

1.How do people feel when they give

- (a) one pound?
- (b) ten pounds?

OR

How does a man often feel when he hands out a one-pound note?

OR

What does a person experience if he hands out a ten-pound note?

OR

In the poem 'Money Madness', a person experiences a _____ if he hands out a ten-pound note.

Ans:(a) They feel a pang of pain.

(b) They experience a trembling movement caused by fear.

2.“Money has got us down” could mean

- (a) it has ruined us.
- (b) it has made us tremulous.
- (c) it has made us greedy.
- (d) it has made us its slaves.

Ans: (d) It has made us its slaves.

3.How are people, without money, usually treated?

OR

What would happen to an individual if he has no money?

OR

What would they give an individual if he has no money?

Ans: People without money are treated with disdain. They are made to eat dirt which means made to accept criticism and blame without complaint.

4.What things should be made available free of cost to all the people in the world?

Ans: Bread, shelter and fire. By this D.H. Lawrence means the basic necessities of life without which man cannot survive.

5.The speaker is frightened of

- (a) having no money.
- (b) money madness.
- (c) eating dirt.

Ans: (b) money madness.

6.What will happen if we do not regain our sanity about money?

Ans: If we do not regain our sanity, we will end up killing one another.

Money Madness Comprehension II :

1.How does money trigger fear in an individual?

Ans: The fact that an individual gets judged by the money he possesses makes him feel worthless when he has no money. In addition, though he might be given some bread to keep himself alive, along with this he is made to eat dirt. He is made to kowtow all that the moneyed man says to him. The prospect of this slavish existence among the money-mad people who wouldn't hesitate to kill one another for money can frighten an individual.

2.How does an individual measure the value of another individual in terms of money?

OR

What is the basis on which we estimate another human being?

Ans: Everyone is obsessed with money and that is why all other virtues of an individual are overlooked if he is unfortunate enough not to possess wealth. The only question asked is how much an individual is worth. The expected answer is in terms of material possessions. Even if a person possesses the knowledge and various other talents, none of that would get reckoned with. That is why the speaker says that money has got us down to the position of slaves because we are all slaves of money or slaves of people with money. It has made us forget our self-worth and self-dignity.

Money Madness Comprehension III :

1.Collective madness for money affects the individuals also. How does the poem bring this out?

OR

How does money madness affect an individual?

Ans: Collective madness for money affects an individual because he too has his share of guilt in giving too much value for money. This is clear from the fact that no individual is able to part with money with equanimity of heart. There are pangs and tremors every time an individual has to give one pound or ten pounds away. However, an individual cannot be held solely responsible for the evil of money-mindedness. He cannot escape the negative impact of the system which is money-centred. When money is needed even for basic necessities of life, he cannot say that he will remain free of money-mindedness. His whole life is a struggle to make enough money to make both ends meet. He knows that without money he ceases to be an entity for others. His dread is being at the receiving end of charity that would divest him of all dignity. He knows that some bread would be thrown at him to keep him alive, but it would be done so scornfully that it is equal to eating dirt.

2.What, according to the poet, might happen if people do not regain sanity about money? What solution does he offer?

Ans: If the uncontrolled passion for money continues unabated, people will start killing one other. Primitive societies had the concept of the survival of the fittest, and the fitness of an individual was measured in terms of his physical superiority. But, in contemporary society, the fittest is the wealthiest, and hence everyone hankers after money. When it is not easy to get money, they may even start killing one another.

According to the speaker, this problem can be addressed if the basic necessities such as fire, food and shelter are made available free of cost all over the world, irrespective of their nationality. The argument of the speaker is profound indeed. If we look at the poor people of some countries dying like flies because of lack of food, the plea of the speaker gains immense importance.

Babar Ali - Samarpita Mukherjee Sharma

A Note On The Author :

Samarpita Mukherjee Sharma is the Associate Creative Editor of 'Youth Leader India', the India Chapter of Youth Leader Magazine. She is a member of the dynamic, action-oriented online magazine network focusing on ground-breaking positive change initiatives, portraits, tools and more.

Babar Ali Summary :

In the lesson 'Babar Ali', Samarpita Mukherjee Sharma introduces to the readers the world's youngest headmaster – Babar Ali – through the words of Tanvir, a Youth Leader volunteer. Our pride lies in the fact that this sixteen-year-old headmaster is an Indian, hailing from Murshidabad in West Bengal. Babar Ali's father Nasiruddin Sheikh, a jute seller, though uneducated, believed in the idea that education is man's true religion and sent Babar to school. Babar, a first-generation learner, was a model student in school.

But, what he did after school was more significant than being studious or smart. With the awareness that he was one of the few fortunate boys in the village, Babar was prompted to do something for his fellow youngsters who did not enjoy the same privilege. That is why, after his school hours, in the backyard of his house, in the open air, he started teaching the children who wanted to learn, but had no opportunity to do so and were deprived of their basic right to education.

Even if the government-aided education was free, the other expenses incurred over the uniform, books, etc., discouraged parents from sending their children to school. Hence, the children ended up as maidservants, mechanics, day labourers, grass cutters, livestock herders etc. Babar Ali's vision for these children was different. He wanted to teach these children who were prepared to walk for miles to learn.

Thus came into being 'Anand Siksha Niketan'. In fact, the school started as a game and soon turned into a serious pursuit because children enjoyed learning arithmetic. An institution that came into being with just eight children and one young headmaster, to begin with, in nine years time, had 60 regular attendees, 10 volunteer teachers, 200 students on roll-call and 800 students in total. Fortunately, the school had benefactors in teachers, IAS officers, social workers and religious leaders.

To top it all, even the West Bengal government recognised the school. But, one should remember that the real strength of the school lay in the selfless service of simple people like Tulu Rani Hazra, an illiterate fishmonger, who encouraged parents to send their

children to school; Debarita, a college-going teenager, who had the noble desire to help the underprivileged of society by being their teacher.

The strength of the school also lay in the fact that all teacher volunteers were students who used their free time productively to teach the less fortunate, and the fact that they were not very senior to the students helped them in getting the attention of their pupils.

Thus, we see that the efforts of a single boy resulted in almost a revolution in the field of education and made people believe in the ideal that common people can achieve uncommon feats.

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Babar Ali Comprehension I :

1.Where does Babar Ali run classes for poor children?

OR

Where did Babar Ali teach hundreds of students?

Ans: In his family's backyard.

2.How is Babar Ali's routine described by the writer?

Ans: The writer describes the hard work put in by Babar Ali by placing before his routine. Babar begins the day at 7 in the morning by performing household chores. Though he takes an autorickshaw to commute the first part of the distance between his home and school, he has to walk for five kilometres to reach his school. After school hours, if other boys play football, cricket and other sports, Babar goes to an afternoon school where he is the Headmaster of 800 students. Thus, we see that Babar Ali is a cut above the rest.

3.Give a picture of Babar Ali's school.

Ans: Babar Ali's school is named 'Anand Siksha Niketan'. It is a ramshackle structure covered in half-torn posters. Behind the office of the school, where a gate opens to Babar's home, Babar teaches 800 children in the open air.

4.Why is Babar Ali called 'a fortunate soul' in his village?

OR

Why does the writer consider Babar Ali as coming from a privileged family?

Ans: Babar Ali is called a fortunate soul for two reasons: he is one of the few who went to school and got a formal education. His father – Nasiruddin Sheikh – believed that education is man's true religion and initially supported Babar Ali's venture with his own income.

5.What, according to Babar's father, is man's true religion?

Ans: Education, according to Babar's father, is man's true religion.

6.Why is sending children to school, a costly affair for parents?

OR

Many families could not afford to send their children to school in spite of free education because they still had to pay for ____

Ans: Even without having to pay the school fee, sending children to school is a costly affair for parents as they have to spend money on the uniform, books, etc.

7.Tula Rani Hazra is _____

- (a) a widow
- (b) an illiterate educationalist.
- (c) a literate educationalist

(d) a fishmonger.

Ans: (d) A fishmonger.

8.The teaching staff of Babar Aii's school is made up of

(a) appointed teachers

(b) high school student volunteers.

(c) teachers from other schools

(d) teachers from Aii's village.

Ans: (b) high school student volunteers.

9.Babar Ali gets the children to listen by

(a) using the rod

(b) sparing the rod.

(c) making friends with them

(d) taking advantage of the age gap.

Ans: (d) Taking advantage of the age gap.

Babar Ali Comprehension II :

1.Why do you think Babar Ali took the initiative to start his own school?

OR

Why did Babar Ali take the initiative to start his own school?

Ans: Babar Ali took the initiative to start his own school because he felt the need to do something about a situation which, he felt, was unfair. As mentioned in the lesson, his saga is proof to the saying that one person can make a difference if he is motivated by a strong desire. Even though Ali came from a small village – Murshidabad, he had a dream and he worked towards realising that dream. The dream, however, was not for personal fulfilment. It was, instead, for the betterment of children around him. Ali had the privilege of being educated because of his father's stand on education. But, not all the children in the village had the same advantage. That is why, after attending his school in the morning, Ali started taking classes for the illiterate children of the village in the backyard of his house.

2.'What started as a game resulted in a much sought after school for the unprivileged.' Explain.

OR

Give an account of how Babar Ali's school grew out of a game.

OR

How did Babar Aii's afternoon school grow out of a game of 'school-school'?

OR

How did Anand Shiksha Niketan come into existence?

Ans: It is amusing to know that the school began as a game. When Babar Ali was nine,

he used to play 'school-school' game with his friends and used to act as their teacher. The other children, unlike Ali, had not seen the inside of the school and hence we're excited to play the game with him. But, soon, the game turned into real teaching as children were happy to learn arithmetic. 'Anand Siksha Niketan' got established with eight students on roll. In the course of nine years, the school grew step by step, and from eight, the number increased to 220 students on roll and 800 students in all. The school started receiving both private and government assistance and had 10 volunteer teenage teachers teaching grade 1 to grade 8. It also had 60 regular attendees. The children of the village who worked as maids to cook, clean, wash clothes and dishes for their employees or as mechanics, day labourers, grass cutters and livestock herders came voluntarily to Ali's school in the afternoon after finishing their chores.

What is heartening is the fact that Ali's good work was rewarded as he received help from Babar's teachers, IAS officers, and Ramakrishna Ashram monks. What is even more gratifying is the fact that the school was recognised by the West Bengal State Government and hence students from Baba's school were eligible to pursue their studies in other schools if the need arose. The recognition gave Babar the singular privilege of being the youngest headmaster at the age of 16. Thus, what started as a game resulted in a much sought after school for the underprivileged and inspired other selfless youngsters like Debarita Bhattacharya, a college student, to work as volunteers in helping the have-nots.

3. Do you think that Babar Ali's act of thoughtfulness has enabled poor children to move towards growth? Discuss.

OR

Babar Ali's efforts to teach poor children has brought about a transformation in their lives. Discuss.

OR

Babar Ali's venture has transformed the lives of underprivileged children of his locality. Explain.

OR

Babar Ali's thoughtfulness brought about a change in the lives of many underprivileged children. Explain.

Ans: Undoubtedly, the thoughtful act of Babar Ali has enabled poor children to move towards growth. The village children who would have continued as maids, mechanics, grass cutters and day labourers have the scope of looking for office jobs with the education they have received at Babar Ali's school. It is touching to see that the children are interested in studying. Education is not forced unto them. They are hard-working. They work in the morning to get educated in the afternoon. If not for the afternoon school of Ali, the underprivileged children would have never got the chance of formal education. Even if they had the chance of learning how to read and write, without the proper educational qualification, they would have never had the chance of considering

jobs other than what they could get in their villages. So, it is very clear that Babar Ali is the architect of the lives of hundreds of children in the village.

Babar Ali Comprehension III :

1. According to Nasiruddin, 'education is man's true religion'. How does Babar Ali's school prove this?

OR

'Education is man's true religion' as believed by Babar Ali's father. How did Babar Ali put this into practice?

Ans: If we take religion as the path leading us to virtuous living, we can easily take education at Ali's school as true religion. Babar Ali's school offers to the children of the village the scope of living a meaningful and virtuous life. If we take religion as the means to bring people together, overriding their differences, education that is offered to the underprivileged at Ali's school, bears testimony to this. We see the 'more fortunate' ones like Ali contributing their might towards the welfare of the less fortunate of society. If we take religion as inspiring acts of selflessness, the education at Ali's school can easily be equated with religion because we see not only Ali but a whole lot of young people like him willing to serve others selflessly. Thus, we see that instead of following a ritualistic religion, it is far more self-satisfying to take education as religion and perform good deeds.

2. The increasing strength of Babar Ali's school reflects the transformation in our society's attitude towards education. Substantiate.

OR

How is the success of Babar Ali's school reflective of the change in the society's attitude towards education?

Ans: Earlier, in India, education was considered the prerogative of the higher caste people. The lower caste people were content with the idea of performing manual labour for a living. Even when the rigid caste system lost its prominence in society, education still remained the privilege of the wealthy. The underprivileged of society did not have the dreams of being educated and coming up in life. They took menial tasks as the fate written on their forehead. However, the scenario is different now. The initiative of intellectuals, social workers and the government, has resulted in the progress of the downtrodden and people belonging to the lower rungs of society are encouraged to be educated. Special scholarships are offered to the economically backward sections and backward castes. There is a transformation in the whole educational set-up and we are moving slowly but surely towards an egalitarian society where all have equal opportunities for education and the underprivileged sections are hungry for education.

3. Do you feel that Babar Ali's initiation is a success story? Explain.

OR

Is Babar Ali's initiative of starting a school a runaway success? Comment.

Ans: Definitely Babar Ali's school is a success story. It is a success story not merely because it educates hundreds of underprivileged children after having started with just eight children, but also because it has inspired many like-minded youths like Ali to serve the underprivileged of society. It is a success story also because it has touched a cord, in the hearts of many sensitive people and has inspired them to join hands with Ali in helping the less fortunate. It is a success story because it has not been the victim of government apathy. It is significant that the government of West Bengal has recognised Ali's school which offers parallel education. On the whole, the school is a testimony to human goodness and it gives us enough justification to have faith in the nobility of mankind.

If I was a Tree - Mudnakudu Chinnaswamy

A Note On The Poet :

Mudnakudu Chinnaswamy (b.1954) is a well known Kannada poet who hails from Mudnakudu village in Chamarajanagar District of Karnataka. He has two post-graduate degrees viz., M.Com., and M.A., with a D.Lit. in Social Sciences. He is Director (Finance) in Bangalore Metropolitan Transport Corporation (BMTC) by profession.

Poetry is his passion but has worked in other genres of literature as well, besides having a wide range of interests in culture, theatre and social work. He has brought out 24 books so far, which include six collections of poetry, four of essays, three plays and a collection of short stories.

He is widely translated into many Indian languages apart from English, Spanish and Hebrew. An anthology of his selected poems in Spanish has been brought out by the Government of Venezuela under 'World Poetry Series'.

If I was a Tree Summary :

The poem 'If I was a Tree' places before the readers an age-old custom of discrimination practised in India. The poem satirises the idea of defilement and purification. The unasked but implied question in the poem is about the defilement of the mind. The poem implies that the ones who practise caste system go against God's design. In the different creations of God, there is not a single creature that is considered superior to other creations.

It is clear from the poem that the speaker has suffered the bane of discrimination in human society. His statement that if he were a tree, no bird would ask him what caste he was, makes it clear that the speaker is made to feel ashamed of his caste repeatedly. When he states that the shadow of the tree which is formed on the ground when the sunlight falls on it, wouldn't feel defiled, it is clear that people keep him at a distance and do not allow even his shadow to come in their way as he and his shadow are considered impure. When he talks about the sweet friendship with the cool breeze and leaves, it is crystal clear that in society not many extend to him their hands of friendship.

When he avers that raindrops wouldn't turn back from him considering him a dog eater, it is understandable that people from whom he hoped for sustenance just as a tree gets its sustenance from water, he got only abuse and rejection. When he writes that mother earth wouldn't flee from him with the fear of getting defiled, the picture of upper caste people shooing him away forms in the imagination of the readers. The phrase 'branching out' makes it clear that the hopes and aspirations of the lower caste people

are curbed and they are not allowed to make use of their potential. Through the image of the sacred cow coming to the tree and giving the tree the joy of being touched by the three hundred thousand gods sheltering inside her, the speaker shows that entry to sacred places is denied to him. It could even be an ironical reference to the higher caste people who worship cows as divine but fail to see divinity in their fellow human beings.

It could even be a mockery of the upper caste people who worship thousands of gods but have no respect for their brethren. Finally, when the speaker says that if he is a tree he would have the privilege of being burnt in the holy fire or becoming the bier, it is clear that as a human being, he knows that he would be shunned even after death and wouldn't be allowed a decent death. Thus, as a human being, in life and death, he would be condemned, but as a tree, he would live a life of dignity and joy. Thus the speaker makes it clear that instead of being born as a human being in a society which practices discrimination, it is better to be born as a tree or any other creature in nature, as in nature there is no discrimination.

If I was a Tree Comprehension I :

1.The speaker wants to be a tree because

- (a) trees are not treated as objects of defilement.
- (b) no other creature in nature has the concept of defilement.
- (c) trees are more humane than humans.

Ans: (b) no other creature in nature has the concept of defilement.

2.What wouldn't the bird ask the tree before building its nest?

Ans: The bird wouldn't ask the tree what caste the tree belonged to.

3.When does the sacred cow scrape her body onto the bark?

Ans: Whenever she has itching sensation, the sacred cow would scrape her body onto the bark.

4.How does the speaker want to be purified?

Ans: The speaker wants to be hacked into pieces of dry wood and burn in the holy fire and become pure. The speaker would be happy to become the wooden frame on which a sinless dead body is carried.

5.How does the speaker view his friendship with the cool breeze and leaves?

Ans: His friends would be sweet.

If I was a Tree Comprehension II :

1.Why would mother earth not flee, according to the speaker?

Ans: In the world of nature, there is no discrimination. Stratification in the name of caste is done only in the society of human beings. That is why when a tree tries to spread its roots, mother earth wouldn't flee accusing the tree of defilement. Instead, mother earth would give strength to the tree to get stronger and stronger with its roots being spread wider and wider. Thus the poet shows that discrimination in the name of caste is prevalent only in human society and not in the world of nature. But when we remember that we too have come from nature and go back to nature, it is crystal clear that in the name of God and religion, we have been following this diabolic system of caste, discriminating against our own brothers and sisters.

2.How do the life forces – sunlight and the cool breeze – enforce nature's idea of equality?

Ans: The poem 'If I was a tree' is a satire in which the poet makes an attempt to expose the subtle ways in which the upper caste society has been discriminating against untouchables for centuries. The speaker juxtaposes the world of nature with the human

world so as to accuse human beings of practising untouchability and being meaner than the world of nature.

The speaker speaks in the persona of an untouchable but asks the reader to imagine that he is a tree. Next, he presents a few everyday instances of untouchability. In the poem, the tree is a metaphor for the world of nature and, using the tree as the point of contact between nature and the people, he points out how elements of nature like the 'cool breeze' and the 'sunlight' do not discriminate between people and treat everyone equally. Thus he highlights nature's idea of equality.

The speaker argues that if he was a tree, and when sunlight falls on him, his shadow would not feel defiled. On the contrary, if he were an untouchable and when sunlight falls on him and his shadow falls on a person of the upper caste he or she would feel that he or she has been defiled by the shadow of an untouchable. Similarly, since he is a tree and not an untouchable, the friendship between the cool breeze and the leaves of the tree would be sweet. On the contrary, if he were an untouchable there would be no such sweet friendship. Thus, the speaker wants to argue that the elements of nature enforce equality whereas some sections of human beings enforce inequality.

If I was a Tree Comprehension III :

1. Why does the speaker want to be a tree?

OR

In what way would life have been different if the speaker were a tree?

OR

Why does the speaker believe he will be happier in the world of nature?

OR

Why does the speaker wish to be a tree?

Ans: It is clear from the poem that the speaker has suffered the bane of discrimination in human society. His statement that if he were a tree no bird would ask him what caste he is, makes it clear that the speaker is made to feel ashamed of his caste repeatedly. When he states that the shadow of the tree which is formed on the ground when the sunlight falls on it, wouldn't feel defiled, it is clear that people keep him at a distance and do not allow even his shadow to come in their way as he and his shadow are considered impure. When he talks about the sweet friendship with the cool breeze and leaves, it is clear that in society not many extend to him their hands of friendship.

When he avers that raindrops wouldn't turn back from him considering him a dog eater, it is understandable that people from whom he hoped for sustenance just as a tree gets its sustenance from water, he got only abuse and rejection. When he writes that mother earth wouldn't flee from him with the fear of getting defiled, the picture of upper caste people shooing him away forms in the imagination of the readers. The phrase

'branching out' makes it clear that the hopes and aspirations of the lower caste people are curbed and they are not allowed to make use of their potential.

Through the image of the sacred cow coming to the tree and giving the tree the joy of being touched by the three hundred thousand gods sheltering inside her, the speaker shows that entry to sacred places is denied to him. It could even be an ironical reference to the higher caste people who worship cows as divine but fail to see divinity in their fellow human beings. It could even be a mockery of the upper caste people who worship thousands of gods but have no respect for their brethren.

Finally, when the speaker says that if he were a tree he would have the privilege of being burnt in the holy fire or becoming the bier, it is clear that, as a human being, he knows that he would be shunned even after death and wouldn't be allowed a decent death. Thus, as a human being, in life and death, he would be condemned, but as a tree, he would live a life of dignity and joy. Thus the speaker makes it clear that instead of being born as a human being in a society which practises discrimination, it is better to be born as a tree or any other creature in nature, as in nature there is no discrimination.

2.The poem is a satire of social discrimination. Discuss.

OR

How does the poet bring out social discrimination in society?

Ans: The poem is a social satire. By juxtaposing the world of nature and the world of human beings, the poet points out that human beings, who are supposed to be God's supreme creation, have gone against the natural order of nature and have made life miserable for their fellow human beings. Caste is purely a man-made construct and with this diabolic idea, powerful sections of society have managed to put down the meek, age after age. The poem voices the injustice meted out to certain sections of society in the name of caste.

3.The speaker brings out the concepts of defilement and purification. How is the meaninglessness of the practice brought out?

OR

Analyse the concepts of defilement and purification as illustrated in 'If I was a Tree'.

Ans: The poem makes it very clear that the question of defilement and purification are man-made concepts. How can one human being be different from another? What is meant by purification?

The poem makes it very clear that the concept of defilement is in the mind of man and hence purification should be the purification of such evil thoughts in the mind of man. Ironically, purification doesn't mean the purification of the so-called outcasts. The purification is the purification of those who have by mistake come into contact with the outcasts. There are different rituals which are performed in the name of purification.

Watchman of the Lake - R.K.Narayan

A Note On The Author :

R.K. Narayan (1906 – 2001) was an Indian author whose works of fiction include a series of books about people and their interactions in an imagined town in India called Malgudi. He is one of three leading figures of early Indian literature in English, along with Mulk Raj Anand and Raja Rao. He is credited with bringing Indian literature in English to the rest of the world and is regarded as one of India's greatest English novelists. Narayan rarely wrote plays, and the present one is said to be a dramatised version of his short story, 'The Watchman'.

Watchman of the Lake Summary :

The title of the play 'Watchman of the Lake' by R.K. Narayan refers to a watchman who was instrumental in the lake coming into being. The one-act play which has five scenes unfolds before us the saga of Mara who, against stiff opposition, ensured that the lake came into being, and sacrificed himself to ensure that the lake did not overflow its banks destroying the whole capital of the king who had constructed the lake.

In scene one, we see road makers working under the instructions of the village headman. The village headman, who is rude to all the workers, repeatedly reminds them that the road should be ready within a day before the arrival of the king. When he catches some workmen laughing, he asks for the reason. He is furious to know that the reason behind their laughter is Mara hiding behind a rock. The headman orders his workers to go and catch Mara. When Mara is brought to him, he admonishes (scolds) Mara for distracting the workers and reminds him that he had repeatedly asked Mara to keep away from the workers for the present and the king when he passed that way.

When Mara shows his disobedience, he orders one of his workers – Bhima, who is as huge as a giant, to tie up Mara and lock him up in a cellar. Even when Mara tells him that he wants to inform the king about a dream in which he had seen the Goddess, the headman doesn't relent. The headman cautions Bhima not to listen to the prattle of Mara.

In scene two, we see the king passing by that way. But suddenly Mara jumps down from a tree and places before the king the vision of the Goddess of his dream and her words. Mara says that the place where the king stood was a sacred spot as Hanuman had come there in search of the sanjeevini to revive Lakshmana, fatally wounded in the war.

The stream that arose from where the sanjeevini grew was Veda and she was a plaything for the Goddess. The Goddess kept her in the shelter in summer and made

her flow past the kingdom of the king at other times. So, if a bank was built for her, even during summer, the king's subjects could make use of the water. The king is impressed by the idea that Mara has had the vision of the Goddess and he asks Mara to follow him to the kingdom.

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Watchman of the Lake Comprehension I :

1.Why was the headman in a hurry to complete the road work?

Ans: The king of the land was to pass by that way the next day and the road had to be ready for use.

2.The village headman asked Mara to keep away from the road workers because of _____

Ans: He did not want the king to know that the village had such fools as Mara.

3.How did Mara manage to draw the attention of the king? Why?

Ans: Mara hid among the branches of a tree and jumped down from the tree in front of the king when the king passed that way. Mara did it as he was desperate to tell the king about his dream and what the Goddess had revealed to him in the dream.

4.The Goddess' command to Mara was to _____

Ans: build a tank for Veda so that Veda found a home.

5.How does the king respond to Mara's information about the tank?

Ans: The king does not doubt Mara. He asks Mara to go with him to the palace the next day as he wanted to discuss further the tank to be built.

6.What does Mara advise his son in saving the lake and the creatures?

Ans: Mara reminded his son that he had to be the watchman of the lake after him (Mara). Mara also shared with his son what the Goddess had instructed Mara to do. She had commanded that nothing that flew, swam or walked those parts, where the lake existed, be killed as the place was scared. So Mara told his son that no killers should be allowed there whether they came with arrows for the gulls which skimmed over the water or with the rod for the fish.

7.Why did the visitor approach Mara?

OR

Why did the visitor request Mara for water?

OR

In 'Watchman of the Lake', one day a visitor approached Mara to

- (a) get water to his village
- (b) stop fishing in the lake
- (c) work as watchman of the lake.

OR

Why did the visitor from the farthest village come to Mara?

Ans: The visitor approached Mara for some water from the tank as his village was the farthest from the king's domain and crops parched up and cattle were dying of drought.

8.Mara rushed to the king because he wanted to save

- (a) his own life
- (b) the king
- (c) the lake.

Ans: (b) the king.

9.Mara was trembling at the king's palace because

- (a) he was afraid of the king
- (b) he was drenched in the rain,
- (c) he was worried about the lake.

Ans: (c) he was worried about the lake.

10.On what condition did Mara make the Goddess wait for him?

Ans: Mara requested the Goddess not to carry out her act of devastation until he returned from the capital after informing the king about the danger.

Watchman of the Lake Comprehension II :

1.What was the significance of Mara's dream?

OR

Write about Mara's dream in 'Watchman of the Lake'.

OR

Describe the sacrifices made by Mara to build and to save the lake.

Ans: Mara gets two dreams in the course of the play. The first time, it is the dream of the Goddess who urges Mara to get a bank built for river Veda so that she could find a home for herself. The second time, it is the same Goddess, furious that her plaything Veda has been imprisoned in the man-made bank. When Mara reminds her that it was at her behest that the bank was built, the Goddess, who is in the mood of destruction, retorts that she is now ready for devastation.

After the vision, both the times, Mara works for the general welfare. After the first dream, he wants the bank to be built because he knows that the preserved water would be of great use to the subjects of the king. He undergoes a lot of harassment at the hands of the village headman before he gets to speak to the king. The second time, after the dream, when he realises that nothing can stop the Goddess from the act of destruction, he sacrifices himself in order to save the king and his kingdom.

Thus, we see that Mara is a true saviour of the people. If this is one significant aspect of the dream, there is one more point full of wrath. Maybe she is displeased by selfish people who try to exploit the water in the bank for their own good and wants to teach all a lesson. Even here, it is Mara's sacrifice that comes to the forefront.

The significance of the dreams is that we have no control over divine design. Yet, if we have the nobility of Mara, we can escape the destructive edge of even divine plans.

2.What instructions did Mara give his son about the lake and the creatures? What light do these instructions throw on Mara's character?

OR

What instructions did Mara give his son, Ganga, about the duties of the watchman of the lake?

Ans: Mara reminded his son that he had to be the watchman of the lake after his death. Mara also shared with his son what the Goddess had instructed Mara to do. She had commanded that nothing that flew, swam or walked those parts, where the lake existed, be killed as the place was scared. So Mara told his son that no killers should be allowed there, whether they came with arrows for the gulls which skimmed over the water or with the rod for the fish. These instructions are given by Mara to his son, first of all, show that Mara was obedient to the Goddess.

Secondly, it shows that he was a great lover of nature. Thirdly, it shows his sense of responsibility. He wanted the lake and the bank to be taken care of in an exemplary way. At the same time, he was authoritative too. He did not allow anyone to exploit the bank. Yet, he did not deny anyone the just use of the water of the bank. Thus, we see that Mara was a noble watchman of the lake.

3.Bring out the significance of the sacred spot that Mara describes to the king.

OR

Describe the myth regarding the sacred spot from where the sacred river Veda was born, as narrated by Mara to the king.

OR

What mythological story did Mara narrate about the sacred spot to the King?

Ans: According to Mara's narration, the spot was sacred because Hanuman stood there on the day Lakshmana lay in a dead faint in the battle-field at Lanka. Hanuman was guided by divine omens and came to the spot where the king stood, and went up the mountain to find sanjeevini, with which he revived Lakshmana. In the place of the sanjeevini a stream arose and it flowed past the spot where the king stood. Thus, the place was sacred for two reasons. First of all, the great Hanuman came there; secondly, river Veda, originating from the spot where sanjeevini grew, flowed there.

4.How did Mara react to the Goddess when she appeared before him

(a) the first time?

(b) the second time?

Ans: (a) The first time, when the Goddess appeared before Mara, he recognised her immediately as the divine mother and fell at her feet. He was struck by her grandeur,

and this is evident from the graphic description he gives to the king of the tresses, the stars in her coronet and the ruby on the forehead of the Goddess.

(b) The second time, Mara sees the Goddess in her destructive mood. Her tresses are wild, her eyes gleam with a strange light, her forehead is splashed with vermillion and she carries a sword. This time too Mara falls at her feet, but this time he is frightened and pleads for mercy.

Watchman of the Lake Comprehension III :

1. Was the headman justified in calling Mara a lunatic? Give reasons.

OR

Why did the headman call Mara a lunatic? Give reasons.

Ans: No, he was not. First of all, he gives Mara no hearing at all. Right from the beginning, he has been very insulting towards not only Mara but also the other labourers. Even if he doesn't believe Mara's stories, it is not necessary to be so harsh towards Mara. He even goes to the extent of imprisoning Mara. Moreover, we see that the king has no doubts about the story of Mara. Thus, it is clear that the headman is not justified in calling Mara a lunatic.

2. "Nature is both protective and destructive." How does the play bring out this idea?

OR

The Goddess says "Veda is my plaything" indicating that nature can be constructive as well as destructive. How is this true in the play 'Watchman of the Lake'?

OR

How does the play 'Watchman of the Lake' bring out both the protective and destructive faces of nature?

Ans: The play makes it very clear that nature is both protective and destructive and that we are at the mercy of nature. We see the same river Veda as the life-giver, life maintainer and life destroyer. The play shows it as the whim and fancy of the Goddess, for whom River Veda is a plaything. But, what the author tries to show is that nature can impact us in different ways at different times and we are not in a position to understand why it acts as it does. But, what is important is that we should protect nature and not exploit it.

3. How differently did Mara treat the fisherman and the visitor?

OR

Why did Mara treat the fisherman and the visitor differently?

Ans: Mara is a devoted watchman of the lake and he follows all the commands ordained by the Goddess. That is why he does not harm the tiger that comes to the lake to quench its thirst. For the same reason, he threatens the fisherman with dire

consequences if he tries to fish at the lake again. Mara's duty is to ensure that no living creature got harmed at the lake. At the same time, he does not misuse his power. He is very courteous with the visitor and offers him all the assistance, according to the rules put down by the king. Mara knows that the water of the lake is for consumption and does not deny anyone the rightful use of it.

4. Why do you think Mara asked the king make his son, son's son, and soon, the watchman of the lake?

Ans: Mara's attachment to the lake is such that he cannot trust anyone else with the welfare of it. He has seen selfish people like the fisherman, misusing their power. Moreover, he has guided his son at every point as to how to look after the lake and knows that his son can look after the lake very well. So, when Mara knows that his end is near, he requests the king to grant him his last wish, and that is to appoint his son and his grandsons after his son as the watchmen of the lake. Thus, Mara's selfless attitude is evident even when he makes a request that might seem to others as a selfish one.

5. In what way do you think Mara's sacrifice saved the lake? What 'sacrifices' need to be made to save the lakes today?

Ans: Since the Goddess couldn't make Veda overflow her banks till the return of Mara, with Mara's death, Mara ensured that the river would never overflow its banks. His selflessness in making the king kill him saved the life of the king and all his subjects. In the present time, we have no watchmen to guard our rivers and other sources of water. We have been exploiting the water resources selfishly. We throw rubbish, including factory effluence, into the water; we wastewater; we don't try to preserve water through watershed management, rainwater harvesting etc.

We have polluted our most sacred river – Ganga – beyond measure. It is high time we realised that water is the elixir of life and unless we treat water respectfully, there is no future for us. The year 2013-14 has been declared by the UN as the Year of Water Cooperatives. Let us, at least now, start celebrating the importance of the life-giving water.

The Farmer's Wife – volga

A Note On The Poet :

Volga is the pen name of the well known Telugu writer P. Lalita Kumari (b.1950). She was born in Guntur, one of the big towns and educational centres in the state of Andhra Pradesh. Her stories, novels, and poetry reflect well-articulated feminist positions without compromising either the quality of the literary form or failing to represent the 'reality' of the characters. In her poetry, a metaphor not only facilitates form but also celebrates the 'ideas' depicted.

The Farmer's Wife Summary :

The poem 'The Farmer's Wife' by the Volga begins with the lamentation of the farmer's wife, who laments over the death of her husband. However, in her lamentation, it is clear that more than mourning over the death of her husband, she expresses her grief over the hopelessness of the situation. Her husband has committed suicide because he was unable to face the creditors. However, his act is not considered an irresponsible act. In fact, people may even think of his act as the virtuous act of a self-respecting man who did not want to bend his head and stretch his arm. But the woman points out that, by committing suicide he has left the woman behind, to bend her head and stretch her hand as she has to continue to live at least for the sake of her four children.

The woman ironically adds that bending the head and stretching the arm pose no problem to her as she has always done that. She has always done that as women are always pushed to the low level. But she cannot understand how her husband, who had always asserted his right over her, simply by virtue of being a man, could drink poison and get released from the worldly bonds in a cowardly way. The woman, in her questioning of his act, implies that his irresponsible act has poisoned her very existence. She suggests that when living was worse than death, embracing death was a selfish and even cruel act on the part of the man as he had no thought for the family that he left behind.

The woman is shocked that the man, who could kick and bully her with the claim of superiority over her, could give her the final death blow by committing suicide. At this point, the woman compares the hardship she suffered in the family over the years and the problem of the cotton crop being destroyed that year. She points out that the pain she had undergone was for a longer period of time, but she had withstood it. The problem of the cotton crop, as she says, 'is but yesterday's.' The juxtaposition of the two problems is done to show that men buckle under pressure more easily than women. Men are self-centred too and when they take recourse to escapism, they don't give any

thought to what would happen to their family. They are not worried over the future of their children either. Hence it becomes double jeopardy for the woman.

On the one hand, she has to come to terms with the death of her husband, on the other she has to worry over the future of her children. Here also the poet draws an analogy between the natural crop and the children. The woman points out that when the crop failed, her husband committed suicide; if she were to do the same thing, her children wouldn't have a bright future. She adds that she is not prepared to allow the harvest of her womb to perish. She cannot leave her children helpless like the worm-eaten cotton pods in the wind. The woman rightly points out that meeting one's end is over in a moment. It's not a long struggle. But the struggle in life, for life to sustain and continue, is a long struggle, full of perils. For this, one needs a brave heart.

Only the one with a firm heart will analyse the difficult situation with questions like, 'What of this?' or 'Why is this?' When a person asks, 'What of this?', he probably wonders about what would be the final outcome of all the struggle. When he asks, 'Why is this?', he definitely has a sense of self-pity. Yet he should never lose his reasoning ability and the determination to fight his misfortune. Otherwise, his children would become orphans. That is why the farmer's wife asserts that she would continue to live to teach her children how to live.

She wants to instil in her children the fighting spirit which her husband lacked. That is why she says that she would continue to be alive to teach her children to fight with a clenched fist for not only the basic need of food but also more important things, attaining which might be nothing less than a battle. For this, she pledges to embrace life and not death, though life would present a long and painful struggle.

The Farmer's Wife Comprehension I :

1. Who do 'you' and T in the poem refer to?

Ans: 'You' refers to the farmer and 'I' refers to the farmer's wife. .

2. Why has the speaker's husband committed suicide?

OR

Why did the farmer commit suicide?

Ans: The farmer was in debt and had no crops to sell. He was unable to bear the shame and was unwilling to stretch his hand for help. Being hounded by creditors he committed suicide.

3. What series of contrasts does the speaker draw between herself and her husband?

Ans: The speaker says that her husband was virtuous, but she is a sinner, and he is dead while she is alive. There is irony in this series of contrasts because the farmer, unable to bear the shame, committed suicide without wondering what would be the plight of his wife, left behind to face the creditors.

4. What expressions in the poem bring out the contrast between the speaker and her husband's plight? What difference does this indicate?

Ans: Being a man, the farmer was not used to being subservient to others. He could not bear the idea of bending his head or stretching his hand in front of the creditors. But, being a woman, the farmer's wife was used to obedience and harsh treatment and could pull on even when insulted and deprived. Moreover, being a woman, her motherly instinct made it impossible for her to leave her children behind at the mercy of fate. Though the prospect of bringing up four children in the face of stark poverty is daunting, she faces the challenge and doesn't take recourse to the easier escape route of suicide.

Thus we see that the difference between the man and the woman lies in the way men and women are generally treated in society and the way in which men treat women at home. But the saving grace is the fact that the injustice meted out to women in society and at home makes them strong and gives them the courage to 'embrace life and struggle for life'.

5. The farmer's wife in the poem is

- (a) complaining about her husband's death.
- (b) lamenting the death of her husband.
- (c) angry that her husband has left her.
- (d) bitter about her husband's act.
- (e) worried about her future.
- (f) all of the above.

Ans: (f) all of the above.

6.What memories of her husband trouble her now?

OR

How does the farmer's wife lament over the death of her husband?

OR

What are the memories of her husband that haunt the farmer's wife?

Ans: The woman was ill-treated by her husband in his drunken state. He had abused her both physically and verbally when he was alive. But all this was accepted by the woman because society had made her believe that a man had the right to rule over his wife and even abuse her when displeased as he was the master who went out into the world while she was to deal with family problems. But this idea of the man gets beaten when the farmer is unable to withstand the pressure and commits suicide. Now, the woman has to shoulder the responsibility of both work and home. Naturally, the woman has all negative memories of the man who did no justice to her when alive and did a greater injustice to her by embracing death. The poet wants to point out that while all of us sympathise with the man who was driven to commit suicide, the plight of the woman who has to fend for herself is worse than that of the man who is dead and thereby free of all problems.

7.What does the phrase 'harvest of my womb' suggest? Why is their plight compared to 'worm-eaten cotton pod'?

Ans: The phrase 'harvest of my womb' refers to the four children the woman has borne. Just as the field produces the crop and has the harvest, the woman has produced children. If she, like her husband, takes the easier way out by committing suicide, the children will be left behind like the 'worm-eaten cotton pod.' The woman makes it clear that if the children do not have the parent figure to nourish them they would be like the unripe cotton pods. They cannot reach their mature stage of growth. The poet deliberately uses the simile which compares the orphaned children to worm-eaten cotton pod because it was in cotton-growing areas that the highest number of farmers committed suicide.

8.To what condition had her husband's act of committing suicide pushed her?

Ans: Her husband's act of committing suicide has pushed her to a state which is worse than death. The woman uses the word 'death blow' to show that the death blow of poison which put an end to the farmer's life is easier than the death blow that the wife has to experience in terms of money, dignity and complexity of bringing up the children without any support.

9.The poem ends with

- (a) an assertion.
- (b) a deep sense of failure and despondency.
- (c) a will to survive against all odds.

Ans: (c) a will to survive against all odds.

The Farmer's Wife Comprehension II :

1.Many times the tone suggests the attitude of the speaker. What kind of attitudes are suggested by the words 'virtuous', 'poor sinner', 'he is but a man', 'what of this?', 'Why is this?'

Ans: The attitude of the speaker is cynical. She cannot accept her husband's act of cowardice. She uses the word 'virtuous' ironically. She mocks at the possibility of all praising the farmer as a man of dignity who couldn't bear the idea of taking loans from others. It is customary for all of us to praise the dead and so the farmer would get nothing but sympathy. However, the speaker considers his act cowardly. She says ironically that she will be taken as a 'poor sinner' because she is still alive when her virtuous husband has become a martyr.

She is justifiably angry that the 'man' of the house has turned out to be a coward. The man who abused her because of his advantage of being 'but a man' in a patriarchal society, has left her behind to do the work of a man, that is, earning a living for the sake of the four children. The woman rightly points out that the farmer should have had the strength of character to ask the questions, 'What of this?' and 'Why is this?' and fought against the odds in life to come out of difficulty. But he showed no such courage and left his family behind in dire straits to fend for themselves.

2.What kind of questions does the poem raise about the plight of farmers' widows? Do you think that these questions are only addressed to the speaker's dead husband?

Ans: The poem 'The Farmer's Wife' by the Volga takes up the contemporary problem of many a farmer committing suicide unable to repay the debt taken. It takes a refreshingly different angle of perceiving the problem from the farmer's wife's angle. The poem is an eye-opener because generally when we hear or read about the acts of suicide, we think only about the tragic plight of the farmer who was pushed into the act of committing suicide.

While it is true that the state of the farmer deserves our sympathy, it is equally true that not many of us view the problem from the angle of the family that is left behind. The fact remains that the family would continue to be in the state of insolvency and such a family would be in the worst state of affairs because the so-called 'man of the house' is dead and the family still has no source of income. The widow of the farmer or any other person who is left behind to shoulder the onus is in a very pitiable condition indeed! Hence, the aim of the poem is not to single out one case of suicide, but to throw light on a social problem which needs government intervention to be resolved.

On the one hand, the poem is a plea to all those who give up their struggle not to do so and to brave the storm courageously, and on the other hand, it is a tribute to the women who show greater forbearance than men in facing difficulty and in tackling problems. The poem also mocks at the idea of a man as the breadwinner and his sense of superiority over the woman he takes for a wife. The poem, at yet another level, is an appeal to the government and perhaps even social organisations to support those people who want to live with dignity but are forced to eat dirt.

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Frederick Douglass (An Excerpt from Narrative of the Life of Frederick Douglass, an American Slave)

Frederick Douglass Summary :

'Frederick Douglass' is an autobiographical piece about the life of an American slave. The piece brings to us the gory details of the ill-treatment meted out to the slaves by their white masters. The author begins with references to his birth in Tuckahoe. Ironically, he is not able to say when exactly he was born. He adds that this ambiguity about the age was the lot of all slaves as their masters hid this piece of information from them. The author, who is unhappy over his ignorance about his date of birth, states that he must be either twenty-seven or twenty-eight, going by what his master had said about his age ten years ago.

The speaker's ignorance is not limited to his age alone. He doesn't know who his father is though the common speculation is that his father is a white man. He knows that his mother was a black woman named Harriet Bailey from whom he was separated when he was an infant. He adds that it was the common custom in that part of Maryland that the children were thus separated from their mothers, hindering the natural bond between the mother and the child.

He had seen his mother only four or five times when she met him after walking twelve miles from Mr Stewart's place where she worked as the field hand. She had to be back in the field before the sunrise if she had to escape the penalty of whipping from the slave master. This left the mother and child very little time and scope for communication. The sad outcome of this is that when he lost her when he was around seven, he didn't feel the usual emotions of sorrow.

The sudden death of the mother put an end to whatever chance the author had of knowing who his father was. He cannot be sure at all whether his slave master was his father also, though there were rumours to that effect. But, the prospect of the slave masters being the fathers was not of any relief to the children because such children were under the constant scrutiny of the wives of such slave masters. Such slave masters went to the extent of selling these children to flesh traders to please their white wives. If they didn't do this, they had to either whip their own black children or see their white sons whip their black brothers. Any sign of disapproval by the white man at the gory acts of the white sons made matters worse for both the slave masters and their black children.

The author shares with his readers his experiences with one of his two masters – Captain Anthony by name. If the master himself was cruel, his overseer-Mr. Plummer-

was even crueller. The author places before the readers the bloody details of the master whipping an aunt of his with cowskin until he was too tired to continue whipping her. Mr Plummer, on his part, went around with not only the cowskin but also a heavy cudgel and cut and slashed women's heads horribly.

Despite all these hardships, the author had the optimism of coming out of slavery and he thanks God for giving him this hope and cheerfulness as a youngster.

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Frederick Douglass Comprehension I :

1.What prevented the slaves from knowing their birthdays?

OR

Who kept the slaves ignorant about their age, according to Frederick Douglass?

Ans: First of all, the slave masters preferred it that the black children didn't know their date of birth. Secondly, the children were separated from their mothers as infants and hence lost the chance of getting information about their birth from their mothers.

2.How would the master look at the enquiries about the slaves' birthday?

Ans: The master considered the enquiries improper and impertinent, and evidence of a restless spirit.

3.What was whispered about Douglass' parentage?

Ans: It was whispered that Douglass' master was his father.

4.When was Douglass separated from his mother?

Ans: When he was an infant.

5.Douglass' mother was able to meet him only at _____

Ans: Night.

6.What was the penalty to the field hand for not being in the field at sunrise?

Ans: Whipping.

7.How old was Douglass when his mother died?

Ans: About seven years old.

8.Name the person who was believed to be both Douglass' father and master.

Ans: Captain Anthony.

9.What was Mr Plummer?

Ans: An overseer.

Frederick Douglass Comprehension II :

1.Why wasn't Douglass affected much by his mother's death?

OR

Why could not Frederick remember much about his mother?

Ans: The story of Douglass is the pitiable story of man's cruelty scheming against the natural ways of nature. Douglass narrates to the readers as to how the selfish people who employed children as slaves systematically cut the children from their roots.

He knows that his mother was a black woman named Harriet Bailey from whom he was separated when he was an infant. He adds that it was the common custom in that part of Maryland that the children were thus separated from their mothers, hindering the natural bond between the mother and the child.

He had seen his mother only four or five times when she met him after walking twelve miles from Mr Stewart's place where she worked as a field hand, and each of these times was very short in duration and at night. She had to be back in the field before the sunrise if she had to escape the penalty of whipping from the slave master. This left the mother and child very little time and scope for communication. She would lie down with him, and get him to sleep, but long before he woke she was gone. He does not remember having ever seen his mother by the light of the day. The sad outcome of this is that he does not remember much about his mother and when he lost her when he was around seven, he didn't feel the usual emotions of sorrow.

This is a very sad outcome indeed when we consider the fact that the bond between a mother and a child is the strongest and the most beautiful bond of all and it is unnatural for the son not to feel grief at the loss of the mother. Douglass thus proves that the repercussions of serfdom are more than what meets the eye and the psychological dimensions are far worse than the economic implications.

Frederick Douglass Comprehension III :

1.What kind of hardships did the slaves suffer at the hands of the slaveholder and his mistress?

OR

What were the difficulties faced by mulatto children?

OR

As mulatto children, what wrath did the black slaves incur of their white mistress?

Ans: The mistress always found fault with the slaves, particularly the mulatto children, and ensured that they came under the lash. Whenever she suspected her husband of showing extra favours to his mulatto children which he withheld from other black slaves, her anger was even more and she compelled her husband to sell this class of slaves. If he didn't, the master had to whip such slaves himself or see one of his sons tie up and beat up his brother. Thus we see that the slaves suffered unbearable hardships at the hands of the slaveholder and his mistress, and if the master happened to be the father of the slave, the plight of such a slave was even worse.

2.How does the passage comment on the dreadful experience of slavery?

OR

Describe Frederick Douglass's experiences as a slave.

Ans: The dreadful experience of slavery starts the very minute a child is born. The child is separated from the mother in its infancy, breaking the bond between the mother and the child. Even after that, the mother is not allowed to meet the child often, and this again goes against the possibility of establishing an emotional bond. The child has to suffer the psychological impact of not knowing who the father is. Worse still are the whispers and speculations about who the possible father is. These emotional problems are compounded with physical harassment. The slaves are constantly whipped by not only their slave masters but also others such as overseers and the slave master's white children.

The women are in an even worse situation. We can see that they are used by white men to fulfil their lust. Their plight as field hands is pitiable. They can move out only after nightfall and have to be back at work at dawn unless they have permission from their masters. The fact remains that their cruel masters do not easily give them such liberty. The references to the women who have had their heads slashed and body completely bruised with the beatings given with the cow skin are a testimony to the inhuman treatment meted out to the slaves by their masters.

Thus, the lesson, which is a first-hand narration of Frederick Douglass, makes the readers aware of the heart-wrenching plight of the slaves.

3. In spite of the hardships he suffered as a slave, why does the author say, "slavery would not always be able to hold me within its foul embrace"?

Ans: The author comes out as an optimist who, in spite of horrible hardships, still has the hope of coming out of the bondage of slavery. He thanks God for giving him this tenacity. But, we can see that it is the inner strength of the speaker who opposes the injustice of not only his state but also the plight of all slaves. Being a witness to the tragic plight of his mother and the horrible state of his aunt must have strengthened his resolve to come out of the noose of slavery. It is because of such people who fought against all odds that the slaves got freedom from serfdom.

An Old Woman - Arun Kolatkar

A Note On The Poet :

Arun Kolatkar (1932 – 2004) was educated in Mumbai where he worked as a graphic artist.

A winner of the Commonwealth Poetry Prize, Kolatkar has contributed to 'Kavi', 'Opinion Literary Review', 'New Writing in India' and 'The Shell and The Rain'. He is a bilingual poet and has translated Marathi poems into English. This poem is selected from 'Jejuri', a collection of his poems.

An Old Woman Summary :

An old woman clutches a tourist's sleeve and tags along with him. She wants a 'fifty paise coin'. For this, she offers to show him 'the horseshoe shrine'. This refers to a legend centred around a horse-shoe shaped depression in a rock about Khandoba, the presiding deity at Jejuri, who leapt from that rock onto his horse as he carried his wife with him. This is a legend that the true believer reveres and the sceptic doubts.

The tourist moves away as he has seen the shrine already. The old woman 'tightens her grip' and 'hobbles' along – not giving up so easily. She is persistent. She clings to him like a 'burr' – a prickly seed pod that clings to clothes.

Irritated by this persistence, the tourist decides to 'face her' with an 'air of finality' – he decides that he will not yield to her and thereby wants to put an end to the 'farce'. He presumes that his no-nonsense reaction will deter her. But the old woman's matter of fact question – 'what else' could an 'old woman' do to survive on these 'wretched hills' – strikes the narrator like a thunderbolt.

The stark reality that hits the narrator allows him to 'see' her at closer quarters. When he turns to look at her face, he is shocked. There are two deep sunken eyes that look like bullet holes. Her skin is wrinkled and cracks appear around her eyes and spread beyond her skin. He feels that everything is falling apart. Everything is cracked and in ruins.

The cracks spread beyond her skin to the hills and the sky. There is a catastrophe. The hills crack, the temples crack and the sky falls and shatters like a sheet of glass. But the old woman stands there as a symbol of all-round degradation. The narrator feels ashamed. He is reduced to the small change in the heartland.

In a moment of realization, the narrator/tourist finds himself reduced in his self-esteem. His awakening to the 'real' world makes him feel 'small' – as insignificant as the small coin in her hand.

An Old Woman Comprehension I :

1. 'You' in the poem refers to

- (a) the speaker
- (b) the passerby
- (c) the reader
- (d) anyone.

Ans: (d) anyone.

2. What does the old woman offer to do?

OR

What does the old woman offer the speaker in return for fifty paise?

Ans: Take the speaker to the horseshoe shrine.

3. What does the old woman demand from the tourists for her service?

OR

What does the old woman demand from the pilgrims to show 'the horseshoe shrine'?

Ans: A fifty paise coin.

4. The lines, 'You turn around and face her with an air of finality' suggest that he decided to

- (a) give her a fifty paise coin and get rid of her.
- (b) allow her to take him to the shrine.
- (c) end the farce.

Ans: (c) end the farce.

5. The old woman's eyes are compared to _____

Ans: bullet holes.

6. 'You are reduced to so much small change in her hand.'

Here, the speaker is suggesting that

- (a) one is reduced to an insignificant position.
- (b) one feels that one is being cheated.
- (c) one feels a change in one's personality.

Ans: (a) one is reduced to an insignificant position.

An Old Woman Comprehension II :

1. How is the plight of the old woman depicted in the poem?

Ans: The old woman depicts all those who live below the poverty line in India. If this is a common problem of many because of the problem of unemployment, the woman's age

is an indicator to the fact that the problem is more pronounced in the case of the old. When young they might have done more productive work and earned money. But in their old age, with their physical fitness reduced, they are reduced to the level of forcing themselves upon tourists who want to get rid of them. This can be a very painful experience for the people who have lived with dignity all along but are suddenly reduced to the status of being considered burr.

Arun Kolatkar wants to take up this social problem. He takes up the question of geriatrics – the caring to be shown to the old. Does he ask as to who is responsible for the pitiable condition of the woman? Shouldn't the government take up the problem of the old and take necessary measures to ensure that they live a life of dignity? Kolatkar has a definite purpose in talking about the cracks on her face extending to the hills, temples and the skies. He seems to suggest that just as monuments are part of our heritage, the old are also part of our heritage. We cannot treat them as unwanted, disposable stuff.

When the speaker has this realisation, he has a changed perspective and he finds himself reduced to the position of being a person of insignificance – a cheap person like the small coins in the hands of the old woman. But this realisation has not dawned upon all and that is why the old woman continues to be a tourist guide, which is nothing but a euphemism for a beggar. Her suffering is indicated by the description that she has two bullet holes in the place of eyes. Eyes are normally taken as the indicator of life, but the old woman's eyes are lifeless bullet holes.

Thus, Kolatkar takes up a social problem with a special focus on the aged and tries to awaken in us a sense of responsibility towards our fellow brethren.

2.The old woman in the poem is a self-appointed tourist guide, not a beggar. Do you agree? Give reasons.

Ans: Certainly, the woman is a self-appointed tourist guide because she pesters the speaker to avail of her services even when his intention is to get rid of her. Her persistence is seen in the fact that she hobbles after him and goes to the extent of stopping him by tightening her grip on his shirt. The speaker is more and more annoyed and he wants to get rid of her by being firm in refusing her offer. If we compare the interaction between the speaker and the old woman, we see that it isn't much different from the transaction that takes place between a tourist and a beggar.

The beggars also follow people around pestering them with a demand for alms. But the difference is that if the tour guides offer their service, the beggars don't. This immediately introduces a world of difference between the two categories of people. It shows that even if the tour guides can be as annoying as the beggars, they are people with self-respect.

3.How does the speaker's attitude undergo a change?

Ans: The speaker's attitude undergoes a change because he is posed a question. The old woman's question, "What else can an old woman do on hills as wretched as these?" makes him realise the wretched life of the old woman. The word 'wretched' used with reference to a pilgrim centre makes it clear that places of worship will have no value if people at such places suffer. The question stumps the speaker and he is filled with admiration for the woman who has remained on the wretched hill resolutely. Though ugly and old, she is shatterproof. At this point, there is a sudden reversal of role. The speaker, who had until then considered the old woman insignificant and worthless, suddenly realises that it is he who is insignificant because he has not seen the kind of struggle the old woman has witnessed in her life. Her strength and forbearance are stronger than his.

An Old Woman Comprehension III :

1."The old woman reduces the self-esteem of the speaker and makes him feel that he is nothing more than 'so much small change'." Comment.

OR

How do the stature of the old woman and that of the narrator change at the end?

Ans: Arun Kolatkar's poem, 'An Old Woman', begins with a commonplace experience, but ends in a revelation. At every tourist place, you will meet a self-appointed tourist guide like the old woman in the poem. They need the money and will pester you. They even promise to give you some service in lieu of the money you give them.

Generally, tourists give them something to get rid of them. But a few are firmer and refuse to be influenced by the persuasive attempts of the guides. But what is to be understood is that they do what they do because they have no other means of earning their livelihood. If they don't do what they do, perhaps the only option left for them is to beg. The very fact that they don't beg, but offer their services shows that somewhere deep within them there is some self-respect and hence treating them as burr is inappropriate. Though they are irritating, one should remember that it is the circumstance that has reduced them to this.

Especially in the case of an old woman like the one found on the hills, what else would you expect them to do for their living? When the speaker realises that he has no answer for the question posed by the woman, "What else can an old woman do on hills as wretched as these?", his perception of the old woman undergoes a sudden change. Her eyes which are like bullet holes become a sign of her suffering. The cracks on her face become symbolic of the cracks in a society which do not care for the old and the meek. That is why the speaker says that her cracks extend beyond her skin, and the hills, temples and the sky crack. In other words, everything around her indicates the cracks in

the life of such helpless-people. Yet she stands shatterproof, continuing with life doggedly whereas many others would have cracked under the blows of poverty.

Suddenly the speaker has a new-found respect for the old woman. She becomes a sign of her heritage – the land from which she comes. It is people who dismiss her with a fifty paise coin or shoo her away without giving even that who become as cheap as the fifty paise coin. Kolatkar describes this transformation in a tourist by placing before the readers the tourist's experience at a pilgrim centre.

2.What is the speaker trying to convey through the lines 'And the hills crack, And the temples crack, And the sky falls'?

Ans: The speaker had associated only ugliness and annoyance with the old woman until he had the awareness of her strength as well as her helplessness. With this realisation, she becomes the very symbol of the Indian heritage, and the other things, which had until then been considered monuments of heritage, begin to crack. The poet seems to suggest that it is the Indian heritage in flesh and blood that we have to value.

The reference to the hills, temples and sky cracking and falling could also mean the radical change in the hitherto held opinion of the speaker. The shock the man receives in looking at the sky, perhaps as blue as the woman's eyes which are like bullet holes leads to his enlightened perception of the woman and her connection to this old land. The man notes that as he looks at the woman, and the cracks around her eyes, the cracks seem to spread to the landscape around her: to the hills, the temples and even the sky. But he sees that even though the sky may fall and shatter around her, she is untouched: 'shatterproof'.

In the midst of the life that has reduced her to trying to earn some money as a guide for tourists, and seen only as an old woman to the tourists – not worth their time and barely worth their notice – her resolve is strong. She is a part of the land, as old as it is: she is as immovable. She lives, the man realises, with what is made available to her. With the man's realization, he feels as if he has been reduced to nothing more than his money, for he does not have that kind of connection to his land or his heritage. And perhaps, in light of the trials and tribulations of life, he is really the unimportant one – beyond the small change in his pocket – but she stands, unbreakable and strong.

3.How do you relate the 'cracks around her eyes' to the cracking of hills and temples?

OR

Bring out the significance of the phrase 'cracks around her eyes' in relation to the description of the woman as 'shatter-proof crone'.

Ans: Cracks around the eyes are ordinarily signs of old age. But in the case of the old woman, they signify much more than mere physical features. The old woman's eyes are just two gaping holes filled with empty air, with the hills and the sky. Then the cracks

begin around her eyes, spreading beyond her skin and then the hills crack, the temples crack and the sky cracks and the sky finally shatters and falls like plate-glass. The old woman herself is shatterproof and nothing happens to her.

Only you get instantly reduced to a small change in her hand. It is you who shatter because her eyes are already bullet-holes which are formed with the cracks around the holes. You are shattered with the realisation that the whole system which is guilty of testing the grit and determination of an old woman is full of cracks; people who look at the old woman as a pest are full of cracks; monuments themselves crack in the face of the tenacity of the old woman. Thus the old woman, despite the cracks around her eyes, is actually the only one who is shatterproof.

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Two Gentlemen of Verona – A.J Cronin

A Note On The Author :

Archibald Joseph Cronin (1896-1981), was a Scottish novelist and physician whose works combining realism with social criticism won a large Anglo-American readership. He practiced as a doctor for some years before launching a successful career as a novelist. His first novel 'Hatter's Castle' made him famous. 'The Citadel', 'The Keys of the Kingdom' and 'The Spanish Gardener' are some of his well-known novels. His autobiography 'Adventures in Two Worlds', which is a series of incidents and anecdotes from his life, also earned him great fame.

Two Gentlemen of Verona Summary :

'Two Gentlemen of Verona' by A.J. Cronin is about the selfless life of two brothers – thirteen-year-old Nicola and twelve-year-old Jacopo. The speaker, who is with his companion, comes across them selling strawberries on the outskirts of Verona. Luigi, the driver, cautions them not to buy the fruit from the shabby boys as better fruit would be available in Verona. However, the narrator and his companion feel strangely attracted towards the boys, who, despite their brown skin and tangled hair, have earnest eyes.

Next morning, the narrator and his companion find the boys at the public square shining shoes. The narrator comes to know that the boys undertake many tasks, including showing the visitors through the town, to Juliet's tomb and other places of interest. The narrator too takes this service from the boys and is again attracted by their dignified demeanour. He feels that they have seriousness which far exceeds their age. In the week that follows, the boys prove to be of great use to the narrator. They get for him American cigarettes, seats for the opera and information about restaurants that served good pasta.

The narrator realises that they work very hard, accepting any and every task, including selling newspaper, conducting tourists around the town, and doing other odd jobs for them. The narrator finds them remaining awake till midnight so as to sell the last bundle of the newspaper when the last bus from Padua came there. When the narrator tries to find out why they work so hard, Nicola remains aloof. But, the next day the narrator asks him again as to why they work so hard, eating only black bread and figs. He wants to know whether they are saving money to emigrate to America. Nicola only says that they have other plans, but does not reveal what those plans are.

When the narrator wants to know whether he can do anything for the boys before he left the place, Jacopo asks for a drive to Poleta, the countryside which was 30 kilometres

from Verona, adding that every Sunday they went by hired bicycles. The narrator offers to drive them down himself as he had already given his driver off. Nicola, however, is annoyed that his brother has taken the help of the narrator. On reaching Poleta, the boys go to a large red-roofed villa, telling the narrator that they wouldn't take more than an hour to return. After the lapse of a few minutes, the narrator goes to the villa only to realise that it's a hospital.

A trained nurse there takes him to a cubicle and through a glass partition, the narrator sees the boys in conversation with a twenty-year-old girl, their sister by the name Lucia. The narrator doesn't want to intrude upon the privacy of the boys with their sister and hence goes away without speaking to them. From the nurse, he comes to know that the boys had lost their father, a widower and a well-known singer, in the early part of the war and soon after that a bomb had destroyed their home. They had lived in a shelter that they had built with their own hands from the rubble and were exposed to many difficulties including cold weather. They had hated the German Elite Guard that ruled over Verona for three years and had worked as secret agents against the Germans, in support of the resistance movement. Their small size, young age and knowledge of the surroundings helped them in their dangerous work of carrying letters in their shoes, about the movements of the German troops.

When the war was over, they returned to their sister, an aspiring singer, only to find out that she was suffering from the tuberculosis of the spine. But, they didn't give up. They kept her in an expensive hospital and for twelve months went back to the hospital every week to make the payment. She had shown good progress and the nurse adds that she might, one day, be fully cured, and start singing again. The narrator is deeply touched by the nobility of the boys and marvels at their invincible spirit. Thus we see that the two little boys are the two gentlemen of Verona.

Two Gentlemen of Verona Comprehension I :

1. Where does the narrator first meet the two boys?

OR

Where did the narrator first meet Nicola and Jacopo?

Ans: On the outskirts of Verona.

2. Why doesn't the driver approve of the narrator buying fruit from the two boys? Does he succeed?

OR

Why did Luigi, the driver, try to stop the author from buying fruit from the two boys?

Ans: The driver says that the fruit would be of better quality in Verona. Moreover, he doesn't approve of the shabby appearance of the boys. But, he doesn't succeed at dissuading the narrator from buying fruit from the boys, because the narrator is attracted by the earnest look in the eyes of the boys and buys the fruit from them.

3. List the different things that the boys did to earn their living.

Ans: In addition to selling strawberry, the boys sold newspaper, shined shoes, ran errands such as procuring American cigarettes and opera tickets for the foreigners and acted as their tour guides in not only taking them around the beautiful place but also giving them useful information as to which restaurants served good pasta.

4. In spite of working hard and earning money, the two boys still looked poor because

- (a) they were saving money to go to America.
- (b) they had other plans.
- (c) they wanted to save the money for medical expenses.

Ans: (c) they wanted to save the money for medical expenses.

5. What qualities in the two boys attracted the narrator?

Ans: What attracted the narrator to the two boys was their unrelenting willingness to work. They worked hard, yet never complained; they were mature for their age; had a quiet dignity despite their poverty; were cheerful in spite of facing hardship.

6. Nicola was not pleased when Jacopo asked the narrator to drive them to Poleta as he

- (a) did not want a stranger to become involved with their plans.
- (b) preferred going to Poleta by train so that he could enjoy the scenery.
- (c) did not want to ask anyone for favours.
- (d) did not want to take help from someone he did not know well.

Ans: (a) Did not want to ask anyone for favours.

7. Why did the two boys go to Poleta and why did they want the narrator not to follow them?

Ans: The boys went to Poleta to meet their sister who was being treated in a hospital and make the payment for her treatment. They did not want the narrator to follow them because they wanted to have their own secrets.

8. The narrator did not follow the boys because

- (a) he was not invited to join them.
- (b) he was not interested in knowing what the boys were up to.
- (c) he wanted to respect their privacy.

Ans: (c) He wanted to respect their privacy.

9. What had made the two boys and their sister homeless?

OR

How did the war affect the family of the two boys?

Ans: It was the war that made the boys and their sister homeless. They lost their father in the initial stages of the war and later they lost their home when there was a bomb blast.

10. What does the narrator learn from Lucia's nurse?

Ans: The narrator came to know from the nurse that they were orphans except for having their sister – Lucia. He also learnt the truth that the boys had lived a cultured life before being orphaned as their father, a widower, was a well-known singer at La Scala.

11. The author did not speak to the boys on their return journey because he thought

- (a) the boys would prefer to keep their secret.
- (b) the boys were ashamed of their sister's condition.
- (c) they wouldn't tell him the truth.
- (d) the boys might ask him for money for their sister's treatment.

Ans: (a) The boys would prefer to keep their secret.

Two Gentlemen of Verona Comprehension II :

1. In what different ways were the boys useful to the narrator?

Ans: The boys were useful in many ways. They took the narrator and his companion around Verona.

They got for them American cigarettes, opera tickets, and acted as their tourist guides. They not only took them around a beautiful place but also gave them useful information as to which restaurants served good pasta.

2.What do you understand about the boys' character from their action and behaviour?

Ans: The boys come out as admirable brothers who work selflessly and tirelessly for the treatment of their dear sister. They work day in and day out, but live on black bread and figs. They are shabby in their dress, but keep their sister in an expensive hospital so that she gets the best of care. But, more importantly, they take recourse to honourable work and never try any dishonest ways of earning their living. It is this earnestness in their eyes that attracts the narrator to the boys. They neither beg nor t steal. But they make use of every avenue of work that is possible in the war-hit economy of Verona. However, they are secretive about the reason behind their hard work.

Though Nicola is only twelve and Jacopo eleven, the hardship in life has made the boys very mature for their age. Though the difference is of one year only, we see that Nicola is more mature than Jacopo and acts as the 'big brother'. When the boys work till midnight, trying to sell the last bundle of newspaper to the travellers of the last bus, we see Jacopo leaning against the shoulder of his brother and sleeping, whereas Nicola is very alert. Nicola has a stronger sense of self-reliance and pride. (He is not happy to take unnecessary favours from the narrator and is unhappy that Jacopo has requested the narrator to take them to Poleta in his car.

The role played by the two brothers at the time of the war is also significant. Their patriotism, as well as their hatred for the Germans, is evident in the brave work they carry out as messengers for the resistance movement. Though there is the danger of being shot if caught, they fearlessly carry information about the movement of the German troops to the members of the resistance movement. Though fate has in reserve a cruel blow for them, we don't see the boys complaining about the absence of a comfortable lifestyle, which they were used to, when their father, who was a renowned singer, was alive. Their cheerfulness is heart-warming. They are a fine example to today's youth, who in spite of being blessed with comfort and wealth, are never satisfied with their lot. The resilience of these small children is a model to the youngsters who contemplate suicide even when the problem is a whiff of a thing.

Thus, we see the boys accepting the things that they could not change, fighting against the things which they could change and hoping for the best. They certainly deserve the epithet 'Two Gentlemen of Verona'.

3.The boys are evasive in disclosing their plan to the narrator in the story because

- (a) they thought he could never understand their plight.
- (b) they did not want to share their problem with a stranger.
- (c) they did not want to gain anybody's sympathy.

Ans: (c) They did not want to gain anybody's sympathy.

Two Gentlemen of Verona Comprehension III :

1.Do you think the ending comes to you as a surprise? Why?

Ans: The ending cannot be said to be a total surprise. The narrator gives enough hints throughout the narratio) that there is something secretive about the boys. Along with the narrator, the readers also wonder as to why the two young boys work so hard and save money in such a mature way. However, the readers do get an idea that whatever the secret might be, it would further improve the image of the boys.

So, the ending is not a surprise; but a revelation. The ending is not a sudden twist or anti-climax. It is a befitting ending to a tale of nobility.

2.Had you been in the place of the narrator, would you have behaved differently?

Ans: No. The question of behaving differently arises when a person does not behave in a suitable manner. Some of us may feel that the narrator showed only lip-sympathy because he did not help the boys financially. But, we should remember that the boys have a lot of self-respect. So, it would be a humiliating experience for them to take the help of the narrator.

Moreover, the boys are of the opinion that they have not revealed their secret to the narrator. So, showing to them that he knows about their sister's plight, would again embarrass the boys. That is why the narrator behaves in a very sensible manner by maintaining silence and allowing them to relive their happy moments with their sister.

3.‘Appearances are deceptive.’ How does the story bring out this idea?

Ans: The shabby appearance of the boys along with the hard work they put in, hides the fact that they were used to better times in their past. Their maturity makes one forget the fact that they are little boys of twelve and eleven. When boys of their age would be playing and having fun, these two shine shoes, sell the newspaper and do all kinds of odd jobs. If we think that all this is to earn their living, we are again wrong, because it is for the sake of their sister. The young age and the frail body are a facade to their inner strength.

This deceptive appearance must have helped them in their role as secret messengers against the German troops. Thus we see that the boys prove again and again that appearances are deceptive. However, amidst this facade, the earnestness of the boys shines through their eyes and there is no deception in that.

4.‘War may destroy one’s home but not one’s heart.’ Discuss the statement with reference to the story of the two boys.

OR

What was the impact of the war on the family of the two boys?

OR

What had made Nicola and Jacopo homeless?

OR

How had the war affected the boys in 'Two Gentlemen of Verona'?

Ans: Nicola and Jacopo were leading a happy, comfortable life in the company of their sister and father until the war-devastated their life. Their father, who was a widower, was a well-known singer at La Scala and was taking good care of his children. But he lost his life during the early part of the war. A little later, a bomb destroyed their home and the children were literally thrown onto the streets.

For months they barely managed to keep themselves alive in a sort of shelter they built with their own hands amidst the rubble. During this time they had to suffer a great deal of hardship, one of which was starvation and exposure to the cold Veronese winter. The German Elite Guards established its headquarters in Verona and ruled the city with ruthless severity. Next, when a secret resistance movement took concrete shape, the boys joined the group and worked as secret agents for them. They carried messages to the forces of liberation, carrying information on the movements of the German troops. During one such secret mission, they had to move in the darkness through the mountain passes with letters in their shoes and the chances of their getting caught and shot by the German soldiers were many.

Once peace returned to the city, they came back home only to find that their sister had contracted tuberculosis of the spine. Again they had to work relentlessly day and night to earn enough money not merely to keep themselves alive but also to make regular payments to the hospital ungrudgingly. This they accomplished by shining shoes, selling fruit, hawking newspapers, conducting tourists round the town and exploiting every avenue to earn money.

5. Do you think the story is a telling comment on the true character of a gentleman? Elaborate.

Ans: Who is a gentleman? A gentleman, as defined in the dictionary, is a courteous and honourable man or a man of good social position. When we take the first meaning, we have no problems in declaring that the two boys are courteous and honourable men. It is their courteousness, cheerfulness, earnestness and quiet dignity that appeal to the speaker. It is significant that the boys do not raise their voice in the complaint even once. Their honourable behaviour is evident in the fact that though they have to work very hard, sacrificing sleep, food and pleasure, they never contemplate dishonourable ways of earning money. They are honourable in their love for their sister. Their single goal in life is to get her cured and to see her again as a singer. They are honourable in the brave work they carry out as messengers for the Resistance Movement at the time of war. They are truly the two gentlemen of Verona.

However, if we take the question of social standing, the boys, sadly, do not fit the slot because they are poor. But, we cannot forget the fact that they had a cultured

upbringing when their father was alive. Also, we can rest assured that with the kind of hard work they put in, they would surely achieve a lot in life. Perhaps, after their sister's complete recovery, they would even go the States and rise to an enviable position in society.

While dealing with the question of gentlemanly behaviour, we should not lose sight of one important point. If the two boys are the two gentlemen of Verona, the narrator himself is the third gentleman because he feels for the boys and tries to do something for them. Unlike the driver, who is critical of the shabby appearance of the boys, the narrator is sympathetic towards the boys and buys strawberries from them. He does not go by false values and recognises the true worth of the boys. He is courteous, honourable and is of good social standing too. So, in a way, we can say that if the boys are the two gentlemen of Verona, the narrator is the third gentleman who comes to Verona.

Do not ask of Me, My Love - Faiz Ahmad Faiz

A Note On The Poet :

Faiz Ahmad Faiz (1911-1984) was born in Sialkot, Punjab. He was an intellectual, revolutionary poet and one of the most famous poets of Urdu language from Pakistan. His varied career as a teacher, army officer, journalist, political leader, trade unionist and as a brilliant poet won him a wide audience. He was a notable member of the Progressive Writers' Movement (PWM), a powerful cultural movement to shape the struggle against British Imperialism in India. Faiz was a recipient of Lenin Peace Prize by the Soviet Union in 1962. He was, nevertheless, inspired by South Asia's Sufi traditions.

Do not ask of Me, My Love Summary :

Faiz is said to have recited this poem in a Mushaira (a poetic symposium). It depicts the struggle going on in Faiz's heart, between love and patriotism. In this poem, he abjures the romantic love of the 'beloved' for contemplation of the misery of the world. The poem is a landmark for it leads Faiz to the consideration of the misery he saw around him related to the freedom struggle in his homeland.

The poem can be read in two parts. The first part begins with a couplet or a two-line stanza and is followed by two longer stanzas. In this part, the poet addresses his 'beloved'. He asks his 'beloved' not to expect the kind of love that he had once shown her.

In the next stanza, he narrates and describes the way he had viewed 'life'. In that stage of his life, 'life' looked very young and blooming because of his love for his beloved. Since his 'beloved' was the source of his happiness in life, he could not withstand any kind of suffering afflicting his beloved.

The poet says that the beauty of his beloved bestowed everlasting youth on the spring. He says that the eyes of his beloved were everything to him and everything else failed to please him then. Therefore, when he was in the company of his beloved, he had thought that the 'world' was his. But, in the second half of the stanza, the poet confesses that such an idea was an illusion born out of his imagination. Now, he has come to realize that there are other agonies of the world besides the agony of love, and there are other kinds of solace in addition to the solace of love.

In the second part, he elucidates the 'agonies' and other kinds of solace in addition to the solace of love, that demand his attention. The second part begins with the same couplet asking his 'beloved' not to expect the same kind of love that he had for her once.

In the next (longer) stanza he lists those agonies that demand his attention. They are 'savagery' woven in silk and satin and gold lace, which are dark curses of countless ages, and human bodies sold in street and market-place besmeared in blood. They also demand his attention. He says that even though her beauty compels his attention there are other kinds of bliss besides the bliss of her beauty.

He concludes the second part again with the same couplet asking his beloved not to demand the same kind of attention that once he had for his beloved. In this poem, the word 'beloved' can be interpreted as his 'muse', his country, or his concept of beauty or social change. This poem is said to be Faiz's first experiment with blending the love for the 'beloved' into love for humanity, of turning the pain of separation into pain for all those who suffered under the dark bestial spells of uncounted centuries. In the second stanza, he is obviously referring to slavery, slave trade and prostitution.

Do not ask of Me, My Love Comprehension I :

1. When does the speaker realise what he thought about love was not true?

OR

When does the speaker's idea of love undergo a change, in 'Do not ask of Me, My Love'?

Ans: When he experiences other sorrows and pleasures in the world than what love offered him.

2. 'That's the way I imagined it to be,' suggests

- (a) that the speaker's concept of love is naive.
- (b) the speaker's realisation of realities.
- (c) the speaker's view of love was just a wishful, thinking.

Ans: (b) the speaker's realization of realities.

3. 'for there are other sorrows in the world than love,' here 'sorrows' refers to miseries

- (a) generated by love
- (b) caused by poverty and deprivation.
- (c) caused by jealousy and envy.

Ans: (b) caused by poverty and deprivation.

4. 'You are beautiful still, my love.' Here the speaker is expressing his

- (a) fidelity to his love.
- (b) inability to pay the same undivided attention to his love.
- (c) preoccupations with other issues in life than his love.

Ans: (b) inability to pay the same undivided attention to his love. (Please note that a and c are also not wrong)

Do not ask of Me, My Love Comprehension II :

1. What does the line 'those dark and brutal curses of countless centuries' suggest?

Ans: Faiz Ahmad was a Marxist and believed in the idea of an egalitarian society. When he writes, 'those dark and brutal curses of countless centuries', he probably means the suffering caused by stark poverty which seems to be a brutal curse on the hapless poor. The phrase 'countless centuries' suggests that the poor have no escape from this state of want. At another level, the phrase can be taken as having political allusions. It highlights the betrayal of the founding of Pakistan.

It is to be read as addressed to the nation of Pakistan, which Faiz had embraced with much hope, and with whose political leaders he became disillusioned. The persecution

of minorities, martial laws, public floggings and public executions changed the nature of the creation of Pakistan as a nation. The vulnerable were no longer safe in the land created to protect them.

2.What harsh realities of life have drawn the speaker's attention much more than the beauty of his beloved?

OR

How is the speaker in the poem 'Do not ask of Me, My Love' affected by the harsh realities of mankind?

OR

What realities of life are experienced in the poem 'Do not ask of Me, My Love'?

Ans: The beauty of his beloved cannot keep him riveted to it as other harsher realities of life trouble him. Pitted against his beloved's beautiful face, he sees bodies bathed in blood, smeared with dust, and sold from market-place to market-place. He can also see bodies which are afflicted by a number of diseases and bodies from which pus oozes out. That is why, though his beloved's face is still beautiful, he cannot give his undivided attention to the beauty of the face alone.

3.What transformation in the perception of love do you see in the poem?

OR

What change in the poet's attitude towards his beloved do you notice in the poem?

OR

In the poem, the poet's perception of love changes with time. What reasons does he give for this change?

OR

How does the responsibility of the speaker as a human being change his perception of love in 'Do not ask of Me, My Love'?

Ans: We see that Faiz Ahmad moves from the personal to the political, from the particular to the general in his concept of love in the poem 'Do not ask of Me, My Love'. If the poet was confined to the world of romantic love in the past, he now moves out of it to enter the world of love where he can extend his love to his fellow brethren. It is not that he loves his beloved less, but that he knows that the emotion of love is all-encompassing and it need not remain limited to one individual.

In the past, if one individual happened to be his world, now he sees that the world is much more than just an individual. Earlier, if he thought there was no greater joy or sorrow than the ones resulting from his love for the beloved, he now knows that the world has greater promises and greater trials too. Thus, the speaker accepts the truth that in the past he wove around himself an illusory web of love, but now he knows that such a world was far from being real. Thus we see that the poet rises from the material to the ideal in his concept and avowal of love.

Do not ask of Me, My Love Comprehension III :

1. At the end of the poem we feel ‘the speaker does not love his beloved less, but the suffering humanity more’. Do you agree?

OR

“Suffering of humanity is much greater than the love for his beloved”. Explain with reference to the poem.

OR

“The perception of love changes when one realizes one’s responsibilities”. How is this idea brought out in the poem ‘Do not ask of Me, My Love’?

Ans: Yes, certainly. The very fact that he addresses the poem to his beloved makes it clear that he wants to lay bare before his innermost feelings. Perhaps he has the courage to do so because he knows that his beloved would understand his feelings. If he has to have that confidence in his beloved, then the love between them must be real. It is as if the speaker seeks the approval of his beloved in taking up work that would make him serve the less fortunate in society.

There is a note of pleading when he says, “But I’m helpless too”. It is as if he is saying that unless she understands him and cooperates with him, he will not be able to continue on his path of fighting for the cause of the less fortunate. So, in a way, the poem can be taken as an indirect plea of the poet to the beloved to let him go so that he can take up the national and political cause. So, though at one point of time the poet says that his earlier love seemed to be an illusion, it is clear that he still has a love for the beloved, but is impelled to answer the call of the suffering humanity. It isn’t that he scorns love, but that he understands that it can’t exist in isolation from the world.

The phrase ‘comforts other than love’ suggests the joys of political struggle and comradeship, which are a different and wider form of love. In the repetition of ‘my love’ in the final line, Faiz nevertheless re-emphasises how difficult it is to leave behind his former bliss. This is a poem about the heavy burden of taking on responsibility, and the inner struggle that it entails.

2. Many critics have pointed out in this poem ‘the beloved’ means not just a lover, but country and ‘nationalism’. With this observation, does the poem read differently?

Ans: The word ‘ghazal’ comes from Arabic and has been translated as ‘to talk with women’ or ‘to talk of women’. Much of Faiz Ahmad’s poetry follows the conventions of ghazal, the classical form of traditional Urdu poetry, which had been influenced by Persian literature. But Faiz’s work revolutionises the conventions, extending the meanings of many traditional terms.

For instance, though Faiz often addresses poems to his ‘beloved’, a central word in the ghazal vocabulary in his hands, it refers to both a person and also to the people as a

whole, and even to revolutions. He sees the individual as existing within a wider context. The poem 'Do not ask of Me, My Love' is not written in a strict Ghazal form, although the phrase 'my love' for the beloved is repeatedly used. On the one hand, if the poem can be viewed as a rejection of romantic love, on the other, it is possible to take the beloved as the country or nationalism. It can be argued that Ahmad's initial love for the country underwent disillusionment as the country was guilty of persecuting the innocent. This persecution was the outcome of narrow nationalism.

Political leaders who did not have a wider worldview upheld narrow nationalism which was opposed by Faiz Ahmad. He upheld universal brotherhood and was of the opinion that even as a citizen is proud of belonging to his own nation, he should be equally conscious of the fact that he is the citizen of the world.